THE OBJECTIVE LEDGER · BOOK 2

Together

Staying in tune, talking it through and mending what goes wrong



by Christian

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

The Objective Ledger, Book 2. Together.
By Christian. Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com.

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Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed in short at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-03 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as “Workpaper WP-03: One owner per job”. Blank copies, with room to write, are in *The Workbook*; you can also fill them in free on the website.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as “Tool: Chat analyzer”. You use it and it gives you something back.

The book keeps the two apart: a workpaper and a tool never share a list. Both are free, need no account, and what you type stays on your device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, the cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, bounds in with a playful tip.



Sugarfoot, the steady, gentle pup, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)

Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868
Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Part Three, Chapter 12 (online) says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Chapter 16 (online) about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

1

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 1 · ONLINE: PART TWO · CHAPTER I

Why we get out of tune: communication at home

Why two kind, reasonable people can end up in a tangle neither of them started, and how to get back in step.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. The tangle often isn't about the words
2. Nearly in step is the noisy part
3. Three things knock you out of tune
4. Stress changes your station
5. Nobody has to be wrong
6. Get back in tune before you carry on
7. Go back in with a clear sentence
8. Small daily check-ins keep you in tune
9. Faith, culture and family voices
10. Inside you, and between you
11. On your own: your side of the tuning
12. The fields behind this chapter
13. In real life
14. More kinds of shared life
15. Common mix-ups

IN SHORT:

- **A clash often isn't about the words.** Pace, tone and urgency can be out of step even when both of you mean well.
- **Nobody has to be wrong.** Name it ("we're out of tune"), pause with a time to come back, and slow down.
- **Go back in with one clear sentence:** a fact, a feeling and an ask.
- **A 90-second daily check-in** keeps small drifts small.

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

"I said I'd do it." "I know, I'm just asking when." Four sentences later, nobody is talking about the bins any more, and neither of you can point to the moment it turned.

01

The tangle often isn't about the words.

Two people can each say something reasonable and still clash, because the tone underneath doesn't match. It's like two radios slightly out of tune: together they make a crackle that neither one was making alone.

For example: Two housemates. "Is anyone using the oven tonight?" "Why, did I leave a mess?" A plain question was heard as a complaint.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

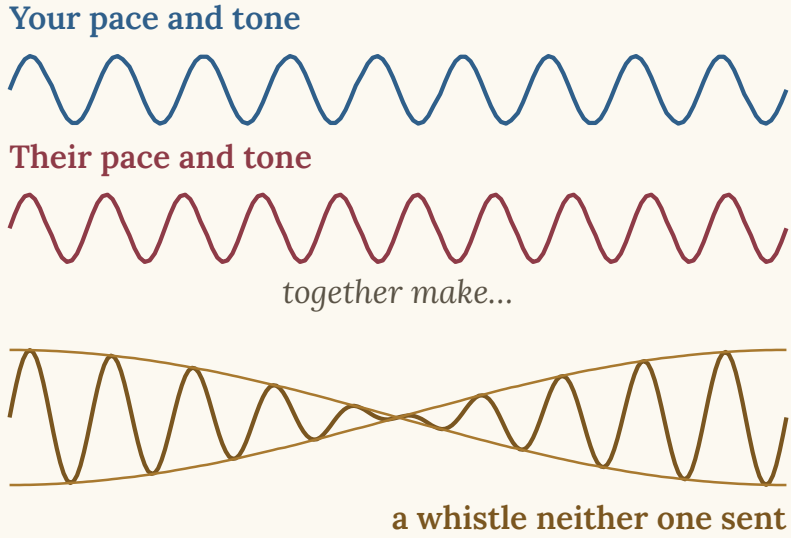
"I think the words were fine. Something in how we said them got crossed."

TRY THIS:

After your next small clash, ask yourself: was it the words, or the way they came out?

The radio whistle

Two reasonable signals, nearly in step.



Not “you started it” or “I started it”.
It started, between us.

Illustration. The picture is borrowed from radio (a “beat” between two close frequencies). Using it for people is this book’s idea.

FIGURE 1 The radio whistle. Two reasonable signals, nearly in step, can make a clash that neither person started: it started between you.

02

Nearly in step is the noisy part.

Radios on very different stations don’t whistle at each other. The whistle comes when they are close but not quite matched. People who know each other well can still clash. Research suggests we check our meaning less with people we’re close to, because we assume they already understand us.

For example: Two sisters who talk every day clash over holiday plans far more than they ever do with cousins they see once a year. Being close means more overlap.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I think I assumed you knew what I meant. Let me say it more clearly."

TRY THIS:
With someone close, check one meaning today: "Just so I've got it right, you mean…?"



TIDBIT
Ooh, Tidbit loves this one: compare your daily rhythms and see whose engine runs fast in the morning and whose at night. Different speeds aren't wrong, just different!

TOOL **Compare your daily rhythms** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration

03

Three things knock you out of tune.

How fast you're talking. The tone, when a simple update is heard as a complaint. And how urgent it feels: "when you get a chance" can mean tonight to one person and next week to the other.

For example: A business partner texts "Need to talk" between two meetings. The other partner reads it as a crisis and can't sleep. It was about a printer. A text loses most of the tone, so urgency is easy to misread.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"By when would be good?" "Is this an update, or a worry?"

TRY THIS:

Add a time to your next request. Not “at some point,” but “by Friday.”

04

Stress changes your station.

When you’re tense, you may talk faster and be more likely to hear a pause as a snub. When you’re tired and flat, your replies get slower and shorter. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks), a thirty-second self-check, helps you guess which one you’re in. It’s a best guess, not a reading.

For example: A dad gets home from a night shift and answers his teenager with one word. The teen hears “he doesn’t care.” He is just running on empty.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

“I’m running low right now. It’s not about you. Can we talk after I’ve slept?”

TRY THIS:

Before a tricky talk, name your state to yourself: calm, revved up or running on empty.

05

Nobody has to be wrong.

Two radios that both work fine will still crackle if they’re slightly off. Arguing about whose fault the static is won’t clear it. Retuning (getting back in step) will.

For example: A grandmother tells her grown-up son, “You look tired.” She means care. He hears “you can’t cope.” Neither of them is wrong about what they meant or heard.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I don't think either of us meant it that way. Can we try that again?"

TRY THIS:

In your next clash, say "we" instead of "you": "We got crossed there."

06

Get back in tune before you carry on.

Say it out loud: "I think we're out of sync." Check how tense you feel. Either of you can call a pause, and the person who paused names a time to come back. Gently slow down, with shorter turns and more pauses. Only then go back to the actual topic.

For example: Two dorm roommates agree on a pause word, "static," on a calm day. Mid-argument about noise, one says it. They stop, and come back at 9pm as agreed.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I need ten minutes. I'll come back at half past."

TRY THIS:

Agree a pause word with someone today, while you are both calm.



FIGURE 2 Retuning, step by step, before you carry on with a talk that has started to whistle.

07

Go back in with a clear sentence.

When you return to the topic, say the fact, how you feel, and what you'd like. "The bins go out early on Wednesday morning. I get anxious when they're late. Could you put them out tonight?"

For example: A co-parent texts: "The swim kit wasn't in the bag. I felt stressed at drop-off. Could you pack it on Sunday nights?" A fact, a feeling, an ask.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"The fact is... I feel... Could we...?"

TRY THIS:
Write one fact, feeling and ask sentence about something small, before you need it.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES
When you go back in, one clear sentence beats a speech. This workpaper helps you shape it before you say it.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

08

Small daily check-ins keep you in tune.

A short chat each day, like the 90-second daily check-in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in), can make tiny corrections before small things drift into a big argument. Habit research suggests small routines at a regular time are easier to keep than big ones done rarely. The quiet, easy stretches are the ones that drift most, so keep it going even when nothing seems wrong (see Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency)).

For example: A long-distance couple in two time zones send one 90-second voice note each morning. It's tiny, but it keeps them in step.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Today I was carrying quite a lot. One thing I liked today was..."

TRY THIS:

Pick a time and a cue, like right after dinner, and try the check-in for three days.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

The 90-second daily check-in

Priya and Dev, a couple on different shifts

The 90-second daily check-in

Person A
Priya

Person B
Dev

Week beginning
5 October 2026

Each day

Day	Person	Load	One thing I appreciated today	One small thing that didn't feel great	One thing that would help tomorrow
Mon	*Priya*	*High*	*You left soup in the fridge before my night shift*	*Woke up to the washing still in the machine*	*A text when you're leaving work*
Mon	*Dev*	*Medium*	*Your note on the kettle*		*Bins out before I go at six*
Tue	*Priya*	*High*	*You kept the house quiet till noon*		*Ten minutes together at the shift change*
Tue	*Dev*	*Low*	*You booked the car in*	*Missed you at dinner again*	

Day	Person	Load	One thing I appreciated today	One small thing that didn't feel great	One thing that would help tomorrow
Wed	*Priya*	*Medium*	*Breakfast together at 8*		*Early night*
Wed	*Dev*	*Medium*	*You remembered my mum's call*		

LOAD THIS WEEK

Priya
2 high, 1 medium, 0 low

Dev
0 high, 2 medium, 1 low

The weekly catch-up

Sore spot that keeps coming up	Times this week	Move to
Washing left in the machine	2	*One owner per job*
Missing each other at dinner	2	*Keep watching*

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. One sentence each, then just listen: no debating, no solving.

Fill in your own: The 90-second daily check-in
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control what you send, whether you check how it landed, and whether you step out to retune. You don't control how it's heard or how fast the other person settles. Matching energy here means matching care and effort, never volume: if someone gets louder, you don't have to follow. Stay at your level, and give the conversation the energy it gives back. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

SATURDAY, 10AM

"We should clear out the spare room at some point." One of you meant this month. The other heard today and has already cancelled their plans in their head. By lunchtime you're both upset about a room nobody has touched.

Faith, culture and family voices

For many couples, faith is where they turn first. If you share a faith, it can be one of your strongest tools for staying in tune.

- **A shared rhythm:** praying together, or a quiet moment after worship, can be your daily check-in.
- **A pause with a purpose:** some couples pray, each on their own, before they come back to a hard talk. The pause still has a time to come back.
- **Your community:** a pastor, imam, rabbi, priest or trusted elder can be a good first person to talk to. Many can also suggest a trained counsellor who shares your faith.

For example (made up): Emeka and Ngozi, married 26 years, do their monthly look-back on a Sunday after church, over lunch. When a talk gets heated, either of them can say, "Let's pray on it and come back at eight." And they do.

Culture shapes how you talk, too. In many families, respect for elders decides who can speak plainly to whom. One habit helps: each of you speaks to your own parents and relatives, after you've agreed the message together.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Can we pray about this and talk again tonight?" "Mum, we love you, and we've thought about it carefully. This year we'll visit in August, not at Easter."

From two faiths or cultures? See Two faiths or cultures, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths).

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Know your own pace, your usual tone and what "soon" means to you. Notice when stress speeds you up or slows you down.
- **Between you and others:** When a clash starts, treat it as a tuning problem, not a moral failing. Retune together, then translate what you meant into words the other person can hear.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I think this is a tuning problem, not a you problem." "What did you hear me say? I want to check it came out right."

On your own: your side of the tuning

Getting out of tune takes two, but retuning can start with one. You can learn your own pace, tone and urgency, so you notice when you're the one running fast or slow.

- Learn your early signs of drifting: a tight chest, a clipped reply, wanting to win.

- Learn how you take words in best, and say it once: “I hear things better in writing.”
- When you drift, step out, settle and come back. You don’t need anyone’s permission to retune yourself.

For example: Hamid lives alone and notices his texts to friends come out short when he’s tired. Now he waits until morning to answer anything that matters.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

“I’m tired, so I might sound shorter than I mean. Can I reply properly tomorrow?”

TRY THIS:

For one day, notice the first sign in your body that you’re drifting. Write it down. More for people on their own: On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:

Step 2: get to know your wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 4: plan what settles you · Part One: who you are today · The whole book on talking it through (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-talk-it-through)

The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 5 of the author’s thirteen fields (see the Preface (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface) or the About page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/about)):

- **Psychology** (Tune how you send and receive): The gap between intent and impact: why a clear, kind sentence can still land as an attack, once pace, tone or urgency slips.

- **Neurobiology** (Read your state first): How stress changes your frequency, and how you sound and hear.
- **Philosophy** (Fix the setup, not the person): Nobody has to be wrong. Zhuangzi's Empty Boat: much of the time, the bump was no one's plan.
- **Behavioural science** (Tune how you send and receive): Small and often. A small routine at a regular time is easier to keep.
- **Holistic therapies** (Read your state first): Body first, argument second. Settle your own state before you go back to the talk.

Two fields, one idea: Neurobiology + Psychology. A tired body changes how words sound and how they're heard. So the same sentence can be fine on Saturday and a fight on Tuesday. Check your state, then say it.

In real life

- **Partners:** "Did you pay the gas bill?" is meant as a reminder. After a long day, it lands as "you forgot again."
- **Family:** A parent asks, "Are you coming on Sunday?" They mean it as a simple question. Their grown-up child hears guilt.
- **Roommates:** A message says, "Can we talk about the kitchen?" One roommate meant a quick chat. The other spends all afternoon worrying.
- **Coworkers:** "Quick question" arrives at 5:55pm. The sender meant tomorrow is fine. The reader thinks it's urgent and stays late.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I meant that as a question, not a complaint. Sorry it came out sharp."

More kinds of shared life

Getting out of tune happens wherever people talk often:

- **Two dads:** "Did you call the school?" is a reminder to one and a test to the other.
- **Three partners:** two speak fast and one slowly, so the slow one gets talked over. More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two)
- **Friends:** a one-word reply after a long message reads as cold, when they were just busy. Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Gaming and phones:** "Five more minutes" means five to one person and a match to the other. Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)
- **Teens and parents:** a parent's worry comes out fast and sounds like anger. For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Adult siblings:** after years apart, an old nickname lands like an old fight. Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- **Foster and kinship carers:** a child who has been hurt may hear a raised voice as danger, even when it isn't. Foster and kinship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- **Different hours, illness, two faiths:** a tired shift worker, a partner in pain, or two family styles of speaking can all shift the tune. Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours) · When one is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Two faiths

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

Common mix-ups

- **"Retuning means giving in."** It doesn't. You still come back to the topic. You just come back when you can hear each other.
- **"If we're out of sync, one of us must be wrong."** Two fair points in two different tones can still clash.
- **"Slowing down means I don't care."** Slowing down is how you show you want to get it right.
- **"A pause means the topic is dropped."** A pause always comes with a time to come back.
- **"We should push through while we're on the subject."** Pushing on through static usually makes more static.

TRY THIS:

Next time a conversation starts to go wrong, pause and say so kindly, instead of pushing through.

Before then, agree on a shared phrase, like "I think we're out of tune." That way it feels like a signal, not a criticism.

For one week, each of you notes one moment you felt out of step. At the end, compare: was it mostly pace, tone or urgency?

When someone says "when you get a chance," kindly ask, "By when would be good?"

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think we're out of tune. Can we slow down?" "I want to get this right, so I'm going to go slower."

A limit to keep in mind: These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking things through ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels

you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A pause is for both of you. If one person is never allowed to pause, or a "pause" is used to punish with days of silence, that isn't retuning. Signs to look out for.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **A clash often isn't about the words.** Pace, tone and urgency can be out of step even when both of you mean well.
- ✓ **Nobody has to be wrong.** Name it ("we're out of tune"), pause with a time to come back, and slow down.
- ✓ **Go back in with one clear sentence:** a fact, a feeling and an ask.
- ✓ **A 90-second daily check-in** keeps small drifts small.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 3 · How communication works
How meaning, tone and listening work
page 43

Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system
Why stress speeds people up or shuts them down
page 25

Book 1 · Your wiring, weather and words
How you like to be spoken to
Self-discovery

Book 4 · Minds that work differently
When pace and tone are a wiring difference
Understanding people

PUT IT TO USE



Six-week program, week 1
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



The 90-second daily check-in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1-in-depth

2

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 2 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 2

Stress and the nervous system: the ladder, flooding, rest and recovery

What stress does to your body and your mind, why kind people say things they don't mean when they are flooded, and the kinds of rest that actually help you recover.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Stress is your body getting ready
2. Stress depends on what you have to meet it
3. The ladder: three everyday states
4. When you're flooded, thinking goes offline
5. Stress adds up, like a tank filling
6. Settle the body first
7. Rest isn't one thing
8. Sleep and stress feed each other
9. Stress is easier to carry when it's shared
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Stress is your body getting ready** for a demand. A little helps. Too much, for too long, wears you down.
- **Three everyday states:** calm and connected, revved up, and running on empty. Each one changes how you think and hear.
- **Flooded means offline.** When stress is very high, listening and careful thinking get much harder. Pause, settle, then come back.

- **Rest is a skill.** Different kinds of tired need different kinds of rest.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **How much are you carrying? and the stress tank** (Part Two, Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3)) work because stress adds up from many small loads. A full tank makes small things feel big, so you check the tank before you judge the moment. Big idea: *read your state first.*
- **The Calm-Down Kit** (Part One, Now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)) settles the body before any words, because a flooded body can't think or listen. Its "come back at a set time" rule stops a pause looking like walking out.
- **The setup score** (Part Two, Chapter II (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2)) counts stress as well as hours, because a split that looks fair on paper can still leave one person running on empty.

MONDAY, 7:52AM

The bus is late, the kids can't find a shoe, and your phone buzzes with a work message. Your partner says, "Have you seen my keys?" and you hear yourself snap, "I'm not your secretary!" A second later you think, "Where did that come from?" It came from a body that was already full.

The last chapter looked at feelings. This one looks at the system underneath them: your nervous system, and what happens to it under pressure. Understanding stress won't make life less busy. It can make your reactions, and other people's, a lot less mysterious.

01

Stress is your body getting ready.

When something needs dealing with, your body gears up: the heart speeds, breathing quickens, muscles tense and stress hormones rise. This is useful. It helps you catch a falling glass, meet a deadline or speak up. The trouble starts when the body stays geared up for too long, with no chance to come back down.

For example: A nurse handles an emergency calmly and well. Two hours later, at home, she can't sit still and cries at an advert. Her body is still running the emergency.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "My body is getting ready for something. That's its job." "The emergency is over. I can let my body catch up."

TRY THIS:
After something stressful, give your body a clear "it's over" signal: a walk, a shower, a stretch or a song.

02

Stress depends on what you have to meet it.

The same event can be easy for one person and huge for another. Stress grows when a demand looks bigger than what you have to meet it: time, energy, money, help, skills or sleep. That's why a small thing can tip you over on a bad day, and why giving someone more support can shrink their stress without changing the task at all.

For example: Two coworkers get the same tight deadline. One has a quiet evening ahead. The other has a sick child at home. Same task. Very different stress.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "It's not the task, it's that I don't have much left today." "What would make this feel more doable?"

TRY THIS:

When something feels huge, write two lists: what it asks of you, and what you have. Then ask what could make the second list longer.

03

The ladder: three everyday states.

The ladder is a picture, not a real ladder. In plain words, it means three states your body moves between during the day. This book uses three plain words for them. **Calm and connected:** breathing is easy and you can hear hard things. **Revved up:** fast, tense, and small things feel urgent or personal. **Running on empty:** flat, slow and short of words.

You move up and down all day. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) is a thirty-second self-check. It gives a best guess, not a reading.

For example: A grandfather minding a toddler all afternoon is calm at two, revved up by four and running on empty by six. The same toddler, the same grandfather. The state changed.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

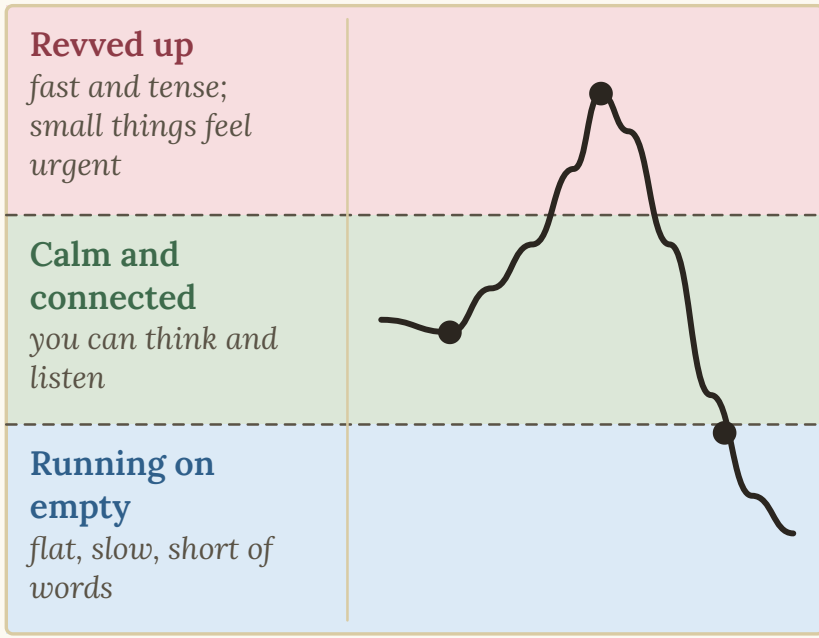
"I'm revved up right now." "I'm running on empty. Can this wait till morning?"

TRY THIS:

Set three reminders today. Each time, pick a rung: calm, revved up or running on empty. No judging, just noticing.

The ladder: three everyday states

You move up and down it all day.



Same grandfather, same toddler. The state changed.

Hard talks go best from the middle band.

Everyday words, not a medical model. A related map is the "window of tolerance" (Siegel, 1999): inside it, you can feel strongly and still think.

FIGURE 3 The ladder: three everyday states. You move up and down it all day; hard talks go best from the middle band.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

The ladder (the sky, in Today's Weather)

Mike, who cares for his wife, Ann

The sky

Pick the one closest to true right now. This is a reading of you, never of anyone else.

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · Gusty: Revved up · *Fogged in: Running on empty*

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · Coworkers · *Someone I care for* · Friends · Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light · Building · *Heavy*

Last night's sleep

Barely slept · Short night · About enough · Properly rested

What's blowing in

Work · Money · *Kids or caring* · *Health* · Family · The house · One conversation · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · Food or water · *Rest* · To move · To be heard · A plan · Company · Quiet · *Someone to take something off me*

YOUR FORECAST

Fogged in today
Running on empty · Very little room today

Talk window
another day is kinder

You were already carrying a heavy day before this. Treat the size of your reaction as a reading on the day, not on whoever is in front of you.

Between you and the person you care for today: do the essentials kindly and let the rest go. If anyone can cover one thing today, ask them.

If you need to say something now: “I’m at the end of what I can carry today. Could you take [one thing] off me?”

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. A heavy reading is information about a day, not a failing in a person.

Fill in your own: Today’s Weather: the sky
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks)

04

When you’re flooded, thinking goes offline.

At the top of the stress curve, the body is in full alarm. Careful thinking, listening and seeing the other side get much harder. Many people call this being **flooded**. You might say things you don’t mean, freeze, or only want to get away. It isn’t a character flaw. It’s a body that needs to come down before the talk can go on.

For example: Two adult siblings start sorting their late father’s things. Within minutes they are shouting about a lamp. Neither cares about the lamp. Both are flooded with grief.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

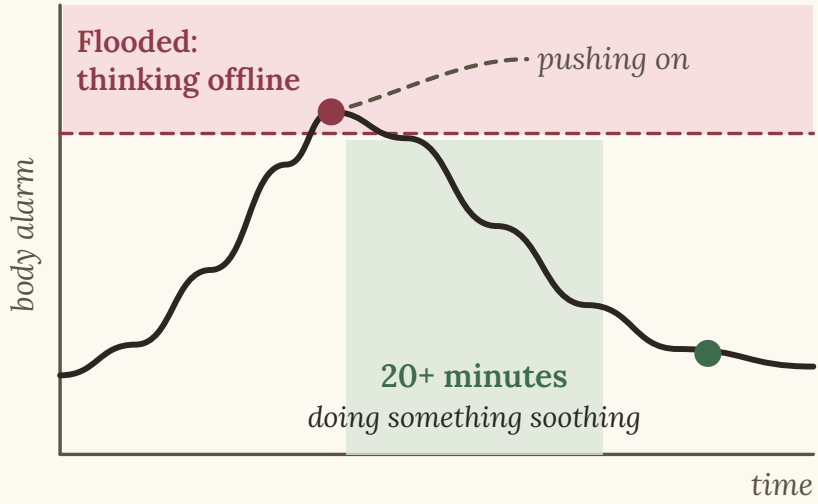
"I'm too flooded to listen well. Can we stop for twenty minutes and come back at four?"

TRY THIS:

Learn your own flood signs: heat, a racing heart, tunnel vision, a loud inner voice. When you notice two of them, pause.

Flooded means offline

Pause, settle, then come back.



- Pause, and name a time to come back.
- Settle the body. Don't rehearse the argument.
- Come back and talk, once you can listen.

Illustrative curve. John Gottman's work on couples suggests a real break of at least about twenty minutes when flooded.

FIGURE 4 Flooded means offline. Pause and name a time to come back, settle the body for at least twenty minutes, then talk. Illustrative curve.

05

Stress adds up, like a tank filling.

Think of a tank (in plain words: how much stress you are already carrying today). Stress from one place spills into the next. Traffic, a hard meeting, a noisy shop and a worrying text can all fill the same tank. By evening, a tiny thing makes it overflow. The last drop gets

the blame, but the tank was nearly full already. Small daily hassles count, not just big events.

For example: A teenager explodes when asked to empty the dishwasher. The dishwasher isn't the problem. A friendship fell apart at lunch, and the dishwasher was the last drop.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "My tank was already full when I got home. That wasn't really about you." "Rough day? You don't have to explain."

> TRY THIS:
> Before reacting to a small thing in the evening, ask: "How full was I before this happened?" Part Two's Chapter III has a simple way to tell.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Stress fills up a little at a time, like a puddle in a long shower of rain. I would know. Five quick questions tell you how full yours is today.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

06

Settle the body first.

You can't think your way out of a body in alarm. You can help the body come down, and the thinking often follows. Slow breathing with long out-breaths, moving, cold water on your face, a familiar song, pressure (like a heavy blanket) or simply leaving a noisy room can all help. Different things work for different people.

For example: A manager feels her heart race before giving hard feedback. She walks round the block once, breathing out slowly. She goes in steadier.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Body first, words second." "What has helped me settle before?"

TRY THIS:

On a calm day, list three things that settle you. Keep the list on your phone. The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) helps you build it.

07

Rest isn't one thing.

Lying on the sofa scrolling isn't always rest. Recovery comes in different kinds: sleep, switching off from work in your head, real relaxation, doing something absorbing you enjoy, and feeling in charge of your own time. Different kinds of tired need different kinds of rest. Being with people restores some people and drains others.

For example: Housemates plan a "relaxing" Saturday party. One loves it and wakes up refreshed. The other needs all of Sunday alone to recover. Both rested. They just needed different things.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I need quiet rest tonight, not people rest. It's not about you." "What kind of tired are you?"

TRY THIS:

Ask yourself: am I body-tired, people-tired, brain-tired or feelings-tired? Pick a rest that matches.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: rest can be a nap, a walk or ten minutes of soft music. Find the kind that suits you, and keep it close.

TOOL **Calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

08

Sleep and stress feed each other.

Stress makes sleep harder, and poor sleep makes stress hit harder. After a short or broken night, small things feel bigger, tempers are shorter and people pull away from each other. In a brain-scan study by Yoo and colleagues (2007), one night without sleep made the brain's alarm centre react more strongly to upsetting pictures.

In a daily study by Gordon and Chen (2014), people reported more conflict with their partner after nights of poor sleep. And in experiments by Ben Simon and Walker (2018), people who had missed a night's sleep kept others at a greater distance and felt lonelier. You can't always fix sleep, but you can notice when it's part of the story.

For example: A nurse coming off three night shifts finds herself in tears over a parking ticket. Her sister says, "You've barely slept. Let's sort it out on Thursday." On Thursday, it's just a parking ticket.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I slept badly. If I'm short with you today, that's why, and it's not about you." "Can we talk about this after we've both slept?"

> TRY THIS:
> Before a hard conversation, ask: "Have we both slept?" If not, pick another time. At night, try the same few calm steps before bed, in the same order, so your body learns the signal. If poor sleep goes on for weeks, talk to a doctor. Sleep problems are common and often treatable.

09

Stress is easier to carry when it's shared.

People calm each other. A steady voice, a hand on the shoulder or just a quiet person nearby can help a nervous system settle. Saying your state out loud also helps others read you right: "I'm stressed

about work" stops a partner or friend from thinking it's about them. Sharing stress isn't dumping it. It's letting someone stand beside you.

For example: A father tells his ten-year-old, "I'm a bit stressed about money this month. It's my grown-up job to sort it, and you're not in trouble." His son stops tiptoeing round him.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I'm stressed, and it's not about you." "Do you want help, a hug, or just some space?"

TRY THIS:
Tonight, tell one person your state in one sentence, and ask theirs.

MONDAY, 7:58AM

Six minutes after the snap, you find your partner by the door. "Sorry. My tank was full before you said a word. Your keys are on the bathroom shelf." They laugh. "Rough start?" "Very." The morning is still busy. It isn't a fight anymore.

In everyday life

- **On your own:** No one notices you're running on empty, so build rest in before you need it. See On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).
- **With a partner:** Agree a pause word on a calm day, and that whoever pauses names a time to come back. See One of you wants to talk now, the other needs space (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw).
- **With friends:** A friend who cancels again may be overwhelmed, not uninterested. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).

- **Parents and children:** A child can't settle until the nearest grown-up does. Your calm is borrowed before it is learned.
- **At work:** A flooded colleague can't take in feedback. Waiting an hour often works better than pushing now. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).
- **Shift work, illness and caring:** Some people run on empty for structural reasons. That calls for a different setup, not more effort. See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours), When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) and Caregivers (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers).
- **If you have ADHD:** Keeping track of everything quietly fills the tank before the day starts. Move the remembering out of your head (a shared list, labelled alarms, one place for keys), and plan hard talks for your better time of day. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

- **"All stress is bad."** Short bursts of stress help you rise to a challenge. The problem is stress with no recovery.
- **"If I'm calm, I can't be upset."** Calm means steady, not happy. You can be calm and sad, or calm and firm.
- **"Pausing is avoiding."** A pause with a time to come back is a way to finish the talk well. A pause with no return is avoiding.
- **"Rest is lazy."** Recovery is part of the work. Bodies and minds that never recover tend to break down.
- **"Everyone should be able to handle what I can."** People have different loads, different bodies and different resources. Compare the load, not the person.
- **"Running on empty means they don't care."** Short replies and flat faces often mean tired, not cold.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Be the calm, not the coach.** A lower voice, slower words and a steady presence help more than "calm down."
- **Lighten the load, not just the mood.** Taking one task off someone's list can do more than any pep talk.
- **Ask what kind of help.** Practical help, company, a distraction or space? Ask, don't guess.
- **Don't debate someone who is flooded.** Offer a break and a time to come back. Facts can wait twenty minutes.
- **Notice long stretches.** If someone has been running on empty for weeks, gently mention it, and help them find support.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "You seem really stretched. Is there one thing I could take off your plate?" "We don't have to sort this now. Shall we pick it up after dinner?"

When to get more help

Stress is normal. Constant stress that never lets up is a warning sign. It may be time to see a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional if:

- you've felt exhausted, dread-filled or numb most days for several weeks, even after rest;
- you can't sleep, or sleep but never feel rested;
- you have physical signs that worry you, such as chest pain, constant headaches or stomach trouble (always get chest pain checked straight away);
- you're relying on alcohol, drugs or other habits to get through the day;

- you feel you can't cope, or have thoughts of harming yourself. If that is happening now, contact your local emergency number or a crisis line.

If the stress comes from being afraid of someone, such as how they will react, what they will do or whether you are allowed to leave, that is not ordinary stress. Your body may be warning you. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not medical advice or diagnosis.

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: your plan for heated moments.

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- The Nervous System Ladder: a thirty-second self-check.
- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps to calm down, alone or together.
- Drift (spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer), Brain Breakers (spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes) and calm games (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pause-and-play): gentle ways to come down.

Reading **pages to read on the website**

- The library: the stress response (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress), appraisal, the window of tolerance, flooding (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships), burnout and slow breathing (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/calm).

More for your situation

- Back: How feelings work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings) · Next: How we see each other (page 63) · All

chapters in the contents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents)

- Part Two, Chapter III: full tanks and different angles
- How to stop fighting: calm steps (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner)
- New baby, sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent) and Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home)
- For teens: big feelings and stress (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Sensory overload at home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Stress is your body getting ready** for a demand. A little helps. Too much, for too long, wears you down.
- ✓ **Three everyday states:** calm and connected, revved up, and running on empty. Each one changes how you think and hear.
- ✓ **Flooded means offline.** When stress is very high, listening and careful thinking get much harder. Pause, settle, then come back.
- ✓ **Rest is a skill.** Different kinds of tired need different kinds of rest.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 3 · Full tanks and different angles
The stress tank in a shared home — Sharing the load

Book 1 · Your wiring, weather and words
Your weather before you speak — Self-discovery

Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune
How stress knocks two people out of tune — page 7

Book 4 · Worry, low mood and trauma
When stress turns into worry or low mood — Understanding people

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
Your plan for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

The Nervous System Ladder
A thirty-second self-check
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress-in-depth

3

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 3 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 4

How communication works: meaning, listening, repair and messages

Talking feels simple, because we do it all day. But every message has to travel from one mind to another, and a lot can change on the way. This chapter explains how that journey works, and what helps a message arrive the way you meant it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Meaning is made between two people
2. Every message says two things
3. Listening is something you do, not something that happens
4. Check, don't guess
5. Hard things land better when they start soft
6. Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill
7. Messages lose their tone on the way
8. Different styles aren't wrong styles
9. Small talk has a job, and it can be short
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Meaning is made between two people.** What you say and what they hear can be different, and nobody has to be wrong.
- **Every message says two things:** the words, and what they seem to say about the two of you.

- **Check, don't guess.** A short question saves a long misunderstanding.
- **Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill.** And small talk is allowed to be short.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **Say it so it lands** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) uses fact, feeling and one clear ask, because every message carries the content and a second message about the relationship. Big idea: *tune how you send and receive.*
- **The 90-second daily check-in and "go back in with a clear sentence"** (Part Two, Chapter I (page 7)) work because mix-ups are normal. Small, frequent repairs keep you in tune better than rare big talks.
- **The Chat analyzer's whole-conversation view (once called the Conversation Reader)** shows where a written conversation lost its tone, because messages lose tone on the way.

THURSDAY, 8:15AM

"Can you call me when you're free?" Ana meant: no rush, I have a small question about the weekend. Her brother read it on the bus and spent the whole ride wondering who was ill. Nobody did anything wrong. The message just arrived carrying something it was never meant to carry.

This chapter explains how a message travels from one mind to another, what can change on the way, and the small habits that help

it arrive: listening, checking, starting soft, repairing, and a few ready-made lines for small talk.

01

Meaning is made between two people.

Words don't carry meaning on their own. The person speaking has a meaning in mind. The person listening builds their own meaning from the words, the tone, the timing and everything they already expect. Most of the time the two match well enough. Sometimes they don't, and neither person can see the gap from where they stand.

For example: A manager writes "Let's chat tomorrow" to a new coworker. She means a friendly catch-up. He spends the evening sure he is in trouble.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think what I meant and what you heard might be two different things. Can we check?"

TRY THIS:

Today, notice one moment when someone took your words differently from how you meant them. Just notice. No blame.

02

Every message says two things.

There is *what* you say, and there is what it says about the two of you. "You're late" is a fact about time. It can also say "I was worried," or "I don't matter to you." People often argue about the fact when the hurt is in the second layer.

For example: Two housemates. "Did you use my pan?" is about a pan. Underneath, it may be "Do you respect my things?" Talking only about the pan won't settle that.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I don't really mind about the pan. I think I wanted to know my stuff matters here."

TRY THIS:

Next time a small thing stings, ask yourself: what did that seem to say about *us*?

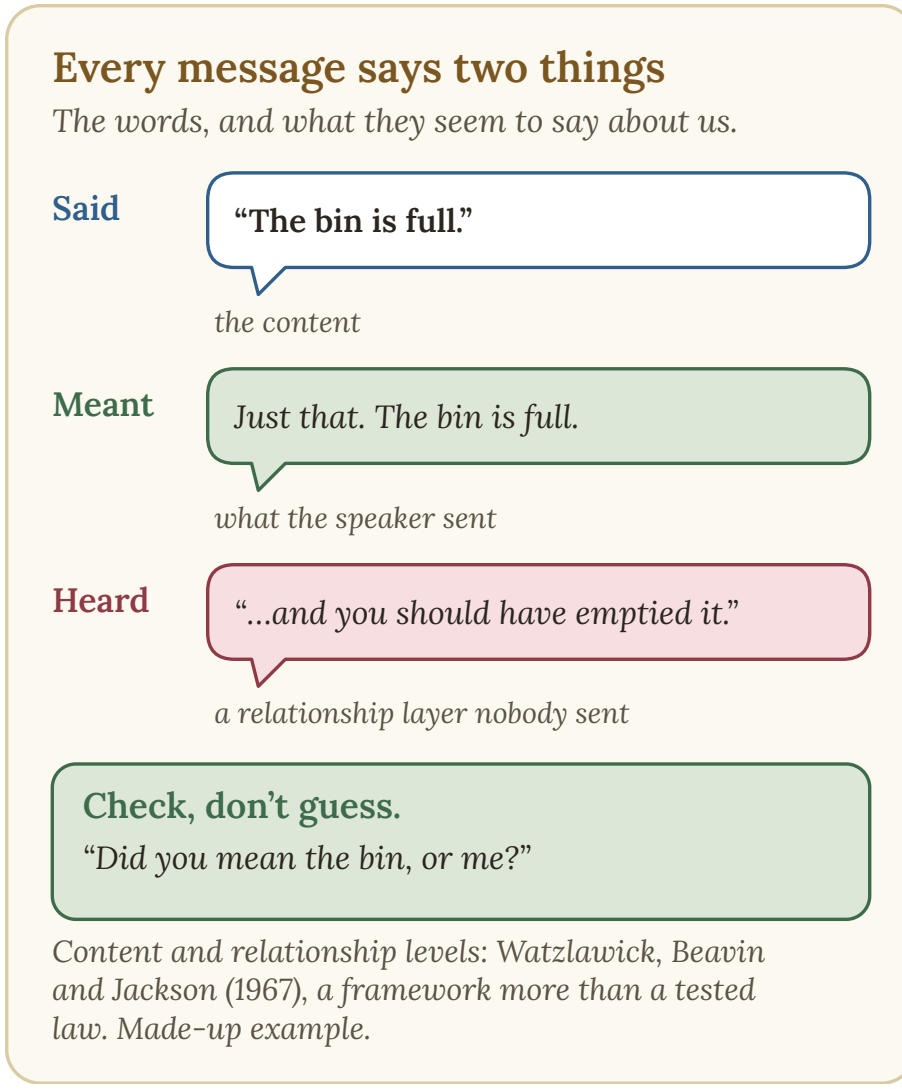


FIGURE 5 Every message says two things: the words, and what they seem to say about the two of you. Check, don't guess.

03

Listening is something you do, not something that happens.

Hearing is automatic. Listening is a choice. Most of us listen partly to reply: to fix, defend, advise or tell our own story. Real listening means following what the other person is trying to say, and letting them

know you got it, before you add anything of your own.

For example: A teenager says school is "pointless." Her dad starts to explain why it isn't. She stops talking. Next time, he tries "Pointless how? Tell me about today." She talks for twenty minutes.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "So what I'm hearing is... Have I got that right?" "Do you want ideas, or do you want me to just listen?"

> TRY THIS:
> In one conversation today, wait until the other person has finished, then say back what you heard before you reply.

04

Check, don't guess.

Once we know something, it's hard to imagine not knowing it. So we leave out steps, assume the other person can tell what we mean, and guess what they meant instead of asking. We do this most with people we know well. A short check costs a sentence. A wrong guess can cost a whole evening.

For example: Two friends plan "something low-key" for a birthday. One pictures a takeaway on the sofa. The other books a quiet restaurant. Both are disappointed, and both thought it was obvious.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Just so I've got it right, you mean...?" "When you say soon, do you mean today or this week?"

> TRY THIS:
> Pick one person you know well and check one meaning with them today, even if you feel sure.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Checking takes ten seconds and saves an evening. When you're ready to reply, this workpaper helps you say it so it lands.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

05

Hard things land better when they start soft.

How a hard talk begins often shapes how it ends. A complaint about one thing ("The bins weren't taken out") is easier to hear than a criticism of the person ("You never help"). A simple shape works for most hard things: what happened, how you feel, and what you'd like.

For example: A woman wants her elderly father to stop driving at night. Instead of "You're not safe anymore," she says: "You had two near-misses last month. I lie awake worrying. Could I drive us in the evenings?"

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"What happened was... I felt... Could we...?"

TRY THIS:

Write one fact, feeling and ask sentence about something small that has been bothering you. You don't have to send it yet.

Say it so it lands

A simple shape for most hard things.

What happened
One specific fact, not a verdict.
"The bins didn't go out on Tuesday."

How I feel
Your feeling, in a word or two.
"I felt let down, because I'd asked."

What I'd like
A small, doable ask.
"Could you set a reminder for next week?"

✕ **Not: "You never help."**
That's about the person, so it starts a defence.

This book's plain-language shape, a cousin of I-messages and Nonviolent Communication; research on such scripts is mixed, and tone matters most.

FIGURE 6 Say it so it lands: what happened, how I feel, what I'd like. A complaint about an action can be heard; a criticism of the person starts a defence.

06

Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill.

Even close, kind people misunderstand each other all the time. What keeps a relationship steady isn't never getting it wrong. It's noticing and fixing it: "That came out wrong," "I think I misread you," "Can we start again?" Small repairs, made often, build trust.

For example: At the supermarket, a stranger snaps "Excuse me!" when you block the aisle. You snap back. A second later you add, "Sorry, long day." They smile: "Me too." A tiny repair, and the moment is gone.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Can I try that again?" "I think I took that the wrong way. What did you mean?"

TRY THIS:

The next time something comes out wrong, repair it within a minute, out loud. Notice how small it can be.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: a mix-up isn't the end of anything. Come back, sit close, and go through it step by step.

TOOL **After a talk went wrong: a step-by-step reset** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

07

Messages lose their tone on the way.

A text or email carries the words but not your face, your voice or your timing. So the reader fills in the tone, and they fill it in with however *they* feel right now. A tired reader hears a tired, cross message. Short replies, missing greetings and late-night timing all get read as meaning something.

For example: A group chat for a school fundraiser. One parent replies "Fine." to a plan. Two others decide she is annoyed. She was typing one-handed while cooking.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Quick reply, not a cross one!" "This isn't urgent. Any time this week is fine."

TRY THIS:

Before you send your next tricky message, read it out loud in the grumpiest voice you can. If it sounds harsh, add a warm word or a time frame.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

Chat analyzer: a whole conversation (once called the Conversation Reader)

Dana and Raj, coworkers on the same project

Chat analyzer: paste a conversation

01 Paste the conversation

Dana: Did the slides go to the client?
Raj: Not yet, still waiting on the numbers from finance
Dana: I needed them by 10. This always happens.
Raj: I can't make finance go faster.
Dana: Forget it. I'll do it myself.

02 Which one is you?

Dana (3 messages) Raj (2 messages)

03 THE READ

What happened
Ends shut down. 5 messages: 3 from you, 2 from Raj. The words don't make it clear what it's mostly about, so the Reader won't guess. It starts calm. There's no one big turn, but some tension creeps in. By the end someone has pulled back. That isn't the same as calm: it can mean they're overwhelmed, or hurt.

Your part · always / never
I said "This always happens", and that isn't fair: it isn't every time. What I meant was: [one recent time, and how it felt].

04 Check your reply before you send it

Your reply
Sorry, that last line wasn't fair. When the numbers weren't in by 10, I felt worried about the client. Could you ask finance for them by 9 next time? I'll chase them with you.

THE CHECK

✓ Says what you need or how it landed · ✓ Makes one clear ask · ✓ No verdicts, always/never, dismissals, sarcasm, jabs, comparisons or shutting the door · ✓ Stays on one topic

Nothing in the wording is likely to add heat. Read it once more as if you were them, then send it when you're calm.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. The Reader looks at one side's part without blaming anyone.

Fill in your own: Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator)

08

Different styles aren't wrong styles.

Some people say exactly what they mean. Others hint and expect you to read between the lines. Some talk fast and overlap; others need a pause to think. Families, cultures and different kinds of minds all shape this. A clash between two styles is usually a translation problem, not a character flaw.

For example: An autistic employee answers "Is this report ready?" with "No, I need two more days." Her manager hears blunt. She was simply being clear and honest. Once they talk about it, he finds her clarity a relief.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm quite direct, so if I sound blunt, I'm not cross." "It helps me if you say exactly what you need."

TRY THIS:
Write one sentence about how you like to be spoken to, and share it with one person this week.

09

Small talk has a job, and it can be short.

Small talk ("Cold today, isn't it?" "Busy weekend?") isn't really about the weather. Its job is to say "I see you, I'm friendly, we're okay." The anthropologist Bronisław Malinowski called this kind of talk "phatic communion" in 1923: talk whose main purpose is bonding, not information. Small moments like this matter more than people expect. Sandstrom and Dunn (2014) found that people who had a short, friendly exchange with a coffee-shop barista felt more belonging and a better mood than people who kept it purely efficient.

But small talk is hard work for many people, including many autistic people, shy or anxious people and people speaking a second

language. The rules are unwritten, it can feel pointless, and it uses energy. A few ready-made lines, sometimes called social scripts, take the guesswork out. Keeping it short is allowed.

For example: A dad who dreads the school gate keeps three lines ready: "Morning! How's your week going?" then "Oh, nice," then "Right, I'd better get going. See you Friday." He no longer dreads it, and the other parents think he's lovely.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

To open: "Morning! How's your week been?" "How do you know Nico?" To keep it going: "Oh, how was that?" To close: "Lovely to see you. I'd better get on." "I'll let you get on. Have a good day." To opt out kindly: "I'm not great at chit-chat, but it's really nice to see you."

TRY THIS:

Write your own three lines: one to open, one follow-up question, one to close. Use them once this week. If you'd rather skip ahead to a real topic, that's fine too: "Can I ask you about something I'm actually curious about?"

THURSDAY, 9:02AM

Ana's brother rings the moment he's off the bus. "Who's ill?" Ana laughs. "Nobody! I just wanted to ask if you're free on Saturday." He laughs too, a bit shakily. Next time, Ana texts: "No rush and nothing's wrong. Quick question about Saturday, call when you're free." Six more words. They save him a whole bus ride of worry.

In everyday life

On your own: how you talk to yourself

Communication isn't only between people. You also send yourself messages all day: "Typical, I always mess this up," or "That was hard, and I handled it." The same ideas apply. Notice the tone, check whether the message is fair, and repair it when it's harsh.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "Is that what I actually mean, or just how it came out?" "What would I say to a friend who did this?"

TRY THIS:
Catch one harsh sentence you say to yourself today, and rewrite it in the way you'd speak to someone you like.

With other people

The same few ideas show up everywhere people talk:

- **Partners:** "We never go out anymore" sounds like a complaint about evenings. Underneath, it may be "I miss you." Answering the second layer ("I miss you too, let's plan something") goes further than defending the calendar.
- **Parent and young child:** "Stop that!" tells a child what not to do, but not what to do instead. "Feet on the floor, please" is easier to follow, and easier to hear.
- **Coworkers:** In a meeting, silence is taken as agreement. Later, a quieter colleague says she never agreed. A round of "Anyone see it differently?" catches this.
- **Housemates:** A note on the fridge saying "PLEASE clean up" reads as shouting, even if it was written in a hurry. A face-to-face chat, or a kinder note, works better.

- **Grown-up child and parent:** "Are you eating properly?" is care in one generation's language and checking-up in another's. Both people can say what they mean and what they hear.
- **Strangers and services:** On a support call, saying "I'm frustrated, but not with you" often changes how the whole call goes.
- **Feedback at work:** Talk about the work, not the person, with one recent example and what good looks like. Then ask, "What's been getting in the way?" When you're the one receiving it, "Thanks. Can I think about it and come back tomorrow?" is a fine first answer. More, with a performance conversation (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-4-communication-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

- **"If they loved me, they'd just know."** Closeness makes us check *less*, not understand more. Saying it clearly is a kindness, not a failure.
- **"I said it clearly, so it's their fault they got it wrong."** Meaning is built by both people. You can be clear and still be misheard.
- **"Listening means agreeing."** You can fully understand someone and still see it differently. Understanding comes first; your view can come after.
- **"Being direct is rude."** Directness is a style. It can be warm and direct at the same time.
- **"Repairing means admitting I'm the bad one."** A repair just says "that didn't go how I wanted." Either person can make one.
- **"Small talk is fake."** It's a way of saying "we're okay with each other." You're allowed to keep it short, or to skip to a real topic.
- **"Texts are safer for hard things."** They feel safer to send, but they are easier to misread. For tender things, add warmth, or talk.

If you want to help someone else with this

Maybe a friend keeps having the same argument with their partner, or your teenager feels nobody listens. You can't communicate for them, but you can help.

- **Listen first.** The most useful thing is often to be the person who really hears them, without fixing.
- **Help them separate the two layers.** "What was it about? And what did it seem to say about you two?"
- **Offer the simple shape.** What happened, how they feel, what they'd like. Let them find their own words.

- **Don't take sides on the other person's character.** You only hear one side, and they may make up next week.
- **Notice if it's more than a mix-up.** If they seem afraid of the other person, gently share Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Do you want me to just listen, or help you think about what to say?"

When to get more help

Most mix-ups can be eased with the ideas here. Some situations need more.

- **When talking makes things worse every time,** a couples or family counsellor can slow conversations down and help both people be heard.
- **When you're afraid of how someone will react,** that isn't a communication problem. Clearer words are not the fix, and you don't have to keep trying. Not safe at home? lists free, private help, and signs to look out for may help you name what's happening.
- **When someone is always "misunderstanding" you** in ways that make you doubt your memory or your sense of what happened, talk with someone you trust outside the relationship.
- **When speaking or understanding is hard for you every day,** because of anxiety, a hearing or language difference, or how your mind works, a doctor, speech and language therapist or counsellor may help. Needing support is not a failing.
- **If you're overwhelmed right now,** start with Upset right now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now).

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

PRACTICE:
try one tool this week, with one real conversation.

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- Chat analyzer: calm replies after a fight.
- Communication style quiz (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz): a playful look at your own style.

Reading **pages to read on the website**

- Effective communication (spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication): the site's complete, plain guide, from listening and timing to hard talks, repair and each kind of relationship.
- Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins): how to hold a hard conversation kindly.
- In the book: Chapter I: Why we get out of tune (page 7) looks at the same ideas at home.

More for your situation

- At work: messages and meetings (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) and for parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents)
- Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting)
- Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance)
- Two faiths or cultures, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths)

- Neurodivergent relationships: communication (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Meaning is made between two people.** What you say and what they hear can be different, and nobody has to be wrong.
- ✓ **Every message says two things:** the words, and what they seem to say about the two of you.
- ✓ **Check, don't guess.** A short question saves a long misunderstanding.
- ✓ **Mix-ups are normal. Repair is the skill.** And small talk is allowed to be short.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune page 7
Pace, tone and getting back in tune

Book 3 · Two kinds of fair Sharing the load
Letting a comment land

Chapter 6 · Healing after hurt page 97
Repair after it goes wrong

Book 1 · Your wiring, weather and words Self-discovery
How you like to be spoken to

PUT IT TO USE

Chat analyzer
Calm replies after a fight
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

Communication style quiz
A playful look at your own style
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-4-communication-in-depth

4

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 4 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 3

How we see each other: perception, bias, and the stories we tell

Why two people can watch the same moment and come away with two different stories, and how to see others, and yourself, a little more fairly.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Seeing is a best guess
2. You see what you're looking for
3. We fill the gaps with stories
4. We judge ourselves by our reasons, and others by their actions
5. Quick shortcuts can lead us astray
6. Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly
7. "Us" and "them" changes what we see
8. Ask, don't guess
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Seeing is a best guess.** Your brain fills in a lot of what you think you see and hear.
- **We fill gaps with stories,** and the story often feels like a fact.
- **We judge ourselves by our reasons and others by their actions.** That gap causes a lot of hurt.
- **Ask, don't guess.** Asking is kinder and more accurate than reading minds.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **Who did what** (the Preface to Part Two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface)) works because everyone sees their own effort more clearly than other people's. Two honest guesses of "I do about 60%" can add up to more than 100%. Writing it down replaces two best guesses with one shared page. Big idea: *see the whole load.*
- **See it from their side (the Perspective Shifter)** (Part Two, Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3)) slows down a habit everyone has: judging ourselves by our reasons and other people by their actions.
- **The Chat analyzer (also called the Signal Translator)** follows this chapter's last idea: ask, don't guess.

> WEDNESDAY, 12:15PM
>
> *You wave at a coworker across the canteen. She looks straight through you and walks off. All afternoon you wonder what you did. At four, she messages: "Sorry I didn't stop, I'd just had a call about my dad." She never saw you. The whole story was yours.*

The first two chapters of Part Three looked inside: feelings, and the stress that shapes them. This chapter looks outward, at how we see other people. It explains why misunderstandings are so common, even between kind and clever people, and what helps.

01

Seeing is a best guess.

Your eyes and ears take in far less than you think. Your brain fills in the rest from what it expects. Most of the time this works well and fast. But it means what you see is partly what you expected to see.

Two people can watch the same moment and honestly see different things.

For example: Two parents watch their son at a football match. One sees him "giving up." The other sees him "being careful with a sore ankle." Same boy. Different guesses.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "This is what I see. It might not be all there is." "What else could this be?"

TRY THIS:
Next time you're sure what someone meant by a look, think of two other things it could have meant.

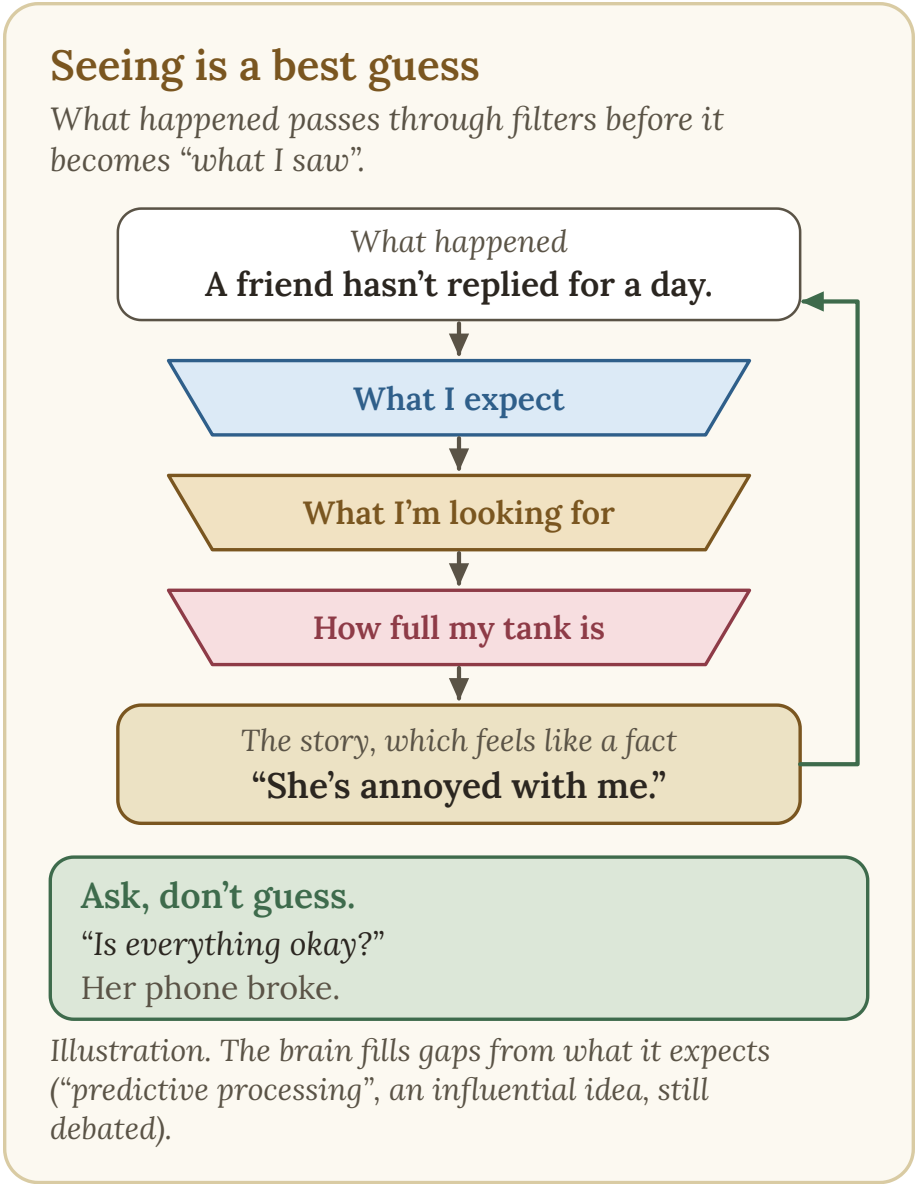


FIGURE 7 Seeing is a best guess. The story that comes out feels like a fact; asking is kinder and more accurate than reading minds.

02

You see what you're looking for.

Attention is like a torch in a dark room. What it lights up, you see. What it doesn't, you can miss, even if it's right in front of you. If you're looking for proof that someone doesn't care, you'll notice every missed call and none of the little kindnesses.

For example: A woman decides her new manager "doesn't like her." For a month she notices every short email. She misses that he gave her the best project.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"What might I be missing?" "If I were looking for the opposite, what would I see?"

TRY THIS:

For one week, write down one kind thing a person you're struggling with does each day. Just notice.

03

We fill the gaps with stories.

When we don't know why someone did something, the mind makes up a reason, fast. A late reply becomes "they're angry." A closed door becomes "they don't want me." The story arrives feeling like a fact. Memory works this way too: each time we remember something, we rebuild it a little, so two people can honestly remember the same evening differently.

For example: A friend doesn't reply for two days. You decide she's fed up with you. She was on a camping trip with no signal.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"The story I'm telling myself is that you're upset with me. Is that right?"

TRY THIS:

When you feel hurt by something someone did, write down the story you're telling yourself. Then write one other possible story.

04

We judge ourselves by our reasons, and others by their actions.

When you are late, you know why: the traffic, the phone call, the child who lost a shoe. When someone else is late, you only see that they're late, and it's easy to think "they're careless." We all tend to blame other people's character for things that are really about their situation.

For example: A driver cuts in front of you, and you think "what an idiot." Next week, rushing to the hospital, you cut someone up yourself, and you know you're not an idiot.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"What might be going on for them that I can't see?" "If I did this, what would my reason be?"

TRY THIS:

When someone annoys you today, think of one situation that would explain it without making them a bad person.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

We know our own reasons and only see other people's actions. Writing out their side, in their words, is a fair way to even that up.

TOOL **After a talk went wrong: a step-by-step reset** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

05

Quick shortcuts can lead us astray.

The brain uses shortcuts to save time. Many are useful. Some lead to unfair judgements: a first impression that colours everything after it, a bad moment that outweighs ten good ones, or a quick guess about someone based on their age, accent, looks or group. Having these shortcuts doesn't make you a bad person. Not noticing them can make you an unfair one.

For example: A housemate decides on day one that the new tenant is "messy" because of one box in the hall. Every bit of mess after that is "proof," while her own mess goes unseen.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Am I looking for proof of what I already think?" "Would I judge this the same if someone I like did it?"

TRY THIS:

Pick one person you've made your mind up about. Look for one thing that doesn't fit your view of them.

06

Everyone feels like the one who sees clearly.

Most of us feel we see things as they really are, and that anyone who disagrees must be missing something, biased or not thinking straight. The other person feels exactly the same about you. Neither of you can see your own lens, only theirs.

For example: Two adult siblings argue about how their parents raised them. Each says, "I'm just being realistic." Both are telling the truth about what they lived through.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think we're both seeing this from where we stand. Can you tell me how it looks from yours?"

TRY THIS:

In your next disagreement, explain the other person's view back to them until they say, "Yes, that's it." Then give yours.

07

"Us" and "them" changes what we see.

People quickly split into groups, even over tiny things. We tend to see our own group as varied and full of individuals, and other groups as "all the same." We give our own side the benefit of the doubt. Spending real time with people from the other group, as equals, is one of the best ways to soften this.

For example: At work, the night shift calls the day shift "lazy," and the day shift calls the night shift "sloppy." After a joint team day, they start saying names instead of "them."

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Would I say this about one of 'us'?" "Who in that group do I actually know?"

TRY THIS:

Have one real conversation this month with someone from a group you tend to see as "other." Ask about their day, not their views.

08

Ask, don't guess.

Imagining yourself in someone's shoes is a kind start. But research suggests it doesn't make us much more accurate about what they think. Asking does. A simple, curious question beats the cleverest guess. "What was that like for you?" is a better tool than "I know exactly how you feel."

For example: A grandmother thinks her teenage grandson hates visiting because he's on his phone. She asks. He's messaging a friend

who is having a hard time, and he likes being at her house because it's calm.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can I check what you meant?" "What was going on for you?" "I might have this wrong. How did it look from your side?"

TRY THIS:

Once today, swap a guess for a question.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

Chat analyzer (also called the Signal Translator)

Zoe, texting her oldest friend, who moved abroad

Chat analyzer

Mode

I'm about to send this Someone sent me this

Type your sentence

You always cancel on me last minute. Can we pick a time for a call on Sunday?

Relationship

Friends

Channel

Text / chat

THE READ

How it may land for most listeners
Some words may hurt. How it may sound: sharp in places.

What stands out
The word “always” (words like “always” and “never” leave no room for the times it went fine).

A clearer way to say it
Lately it’s felt like you cancel on me last minute. Can we pick a time for a call on Sunday?

What changed, and why
always → lately it’s felt like. “Always” and “never” erase every exception, so the listener argues the exception.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. The ask stayed; only the word that would start an argument changed.

Fill in your own: Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator)

THURSDAY, 12:20PM

You see your coworker in the canteen again. This time you go over: “How’s your dad?” She tells you. You sit together. Yesterday’s story about what you did wrong is gone. It was only ever a guess.

In everyday life

- **On your own:** We tell stories about ourselves too. “I always mess things up” is a story built from a few bright memories. Look for the ones it leaves out. See Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself).
- **With a partner:** After years together, we stop checking and start assuming. “I know what you meant” is the most dangerous sentence in a long relationship.

- **With friends:** A friend going quiet is rarely about you. Ask before you decide. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).
- **Parents and children:** Children are often labelled early: "the difficult one," "the easy one." Labels can become lenses that only see what fits. See For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents).
- **At work:** Short emails, flat faces and different working styles are easy to misread. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).
- **In your community:** People from other backgrounds, faiths or generations are easiest to see as "all the same." See Two faiths, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths).
- **With ADHD:** Attention is pulled by what is new or urgent, and can lock on hard. Someone may truly not have seen or heard. Not seeing isn't the same as not caring. Get attention first, and put requests in writing. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-3-seeing-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

- **"I just see things as they are."** Everyone sees through a lens. Knowing that is where fairness starts.
- **"Being biased means being a bad person."** Everyone uses mental shortcuts. What matters is noticing them and checking.
- **"If I imagine their side hard enough, I'll understand."** Imagining is a start. Asking is usually more accurate.
- **"My memory is a recording."** Memory is rebuilt each time. Two honest people can remember the same event differently.
- **"Giving the benefit of the doubt means ignoring what happened."** No. It means checking the story before deciding. If something hurtful keeps happening, that matters.
- **"Their face or tone told me what they meant."** Faces and tones vary a lot between people and cultures, and between neurotypes. They are clues, not proof.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Don't argue with their story first.** Make sense of how they feel, then gently ask, "Is there any other way to see it?"
- **Offer information, not verdicts.** "I know she had a hard week" helps more than "You're being unfair to her."
- **Model asking.** Let people see you check your own guesses out loud: "I assumed he was annoyed. I'll ask."
- **Be careful with labels.** Labels for children, coworkers or family members stick, and then shape what everyone sees.
- **Believe people about their own experience.** Seeing other angles never means telling someone their experience didn't happen.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"That sounds really hurtful. Do you know what was going on for them?" "It might be worth asking. Want to plan what to say?"

When to get more help

Seeing other people's side is a strength. It should never mean doubting yourself when you know something is wrong. If someone often tells you that what you saw, heard or remember didn't happen, that you're "too sensitive" or "imagining it," and you find yourself unsure of your own mind, take that seriously. It can be part of controlling behaviour. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) and Not safe at home? can help, privately.

It may also help to talk to a counsellor or other trained professional if you notice you often feel others are against you, find it hard to trust anyone, or keep getting stuck in the same painful stories about yourself. Those patterns are common, understandable and often change with support.

This chapter is general education, not diagnosis or therapy.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- See it from their side (spreadloveandacceptance.com/perspective-shifter): a free perspective-taking tool.
- Chat analyzer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator): how a sentence might land before you say it.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Wired differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently): how different minds hear the same words.

- Philosophy stories on seeing the other person (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth): the cave, the elephant, the fish and the empty boat.
- The library: the fundamental attribution error (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking), confirmation bias, negativity bias, naive realism, mind-reading and how memory is rebuilt.

More for your situation

- Back: Stress and the nervous system (page 25) · Next: How communication works (page 43)
- Part One, Then: where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then)
- Part Two, Chapter III: full tanks and different angles
- Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts), Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) and For grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children)
- Communication between different minds (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) and For parents
- The whole book (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents) · Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Seeing is a best guess.** Your brain fills in a lot of what you think you see and hear.
- ✓ **We fill gaps with stories,** and the story often feels like a fact.
- ✓ **We judge ourselves by our reasons and others by their actions.** That gap causes a lot of hurt.
- ✓ **Ask, don't guess.** Asking is kinder and more accurate than reading minds.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1 · Where your lens came from — Self-discovery
Where your lens came from

Book 3 · The work nobody sees — Sharing the load
Why the other person doesn't see the work

Book 3 · Full tanks and different angles — Sharing the load
Seven angles on the same moment

Book 4 · Groups, influence and culture — Understanding people
Us and them, and the stories groups tell

PUT IT TO USE

See it from their side
A free perspective-taking tool
spreadloveandacceptance.com/perspective-shifter

Chat analyzer
How a sentence might land before you say it
spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-3-seeing-in-depth

5

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 5 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 13

Anger: what it's for and what to do with it

What anger is for, what to do in the hot minutes, how to repair afterwards, and how to tell when anger has turned into harm. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Anger is a signal about something that matters
2. Anger often guards a softer feeling
3. Anger rises in the body fast
4. In the hot minutes: slow the body first
5. Letting rip doesn't empty it
6. Step back and look from the outside
7. Say it, don't throw it
8. After anger, repair
9. When anger becomes harm
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Anger is a signal** that something seems unfair, blocked or threatening. The feeling is allowed. What you do with it is the part you choose.
- **The first minutes are about the body.** Slow down, breathe out long, and step away with a time to come back.
- **Letting rip doesn't empty anger.** Shouting tends to feed it. Calming the body, then putting it into words and repairing any sharp moments, helps more.

- **Anger that frightens, controls or hurts someone has become harm.** That needs more help, and safety comes first.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **The Calm-Down Kit** (Part One, Now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)) works because anger rises in the body first. Slowing the body is what makes the words possible. Big idea: *read your state first.*
- **"Let a comment land before you react" and "Notice, name, decide"** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) are the step back this chapter describes: look from the outside, then choose.

TUESDAY, 6:10PM

Your brother texts: "Can't take Mum to the hospital on Thursday after all. Sorry!!" It's the third time this month. Your jaw sets and your thumbs start typing fast: "TYPICAL. You never…" Your heart is pounding, your face is hot, and the message is nearly sent.

Many of us were taught anger was rude or dangerous, or grew up around anger that was frightening. But anger itself is a normal human feeling, and it often points at something real. This chapter explains how anger works first, and what to do with it second.

01

Anger is a signal about something that matters.

Anger usually says "That's not fair," "You're in my way" or "Someone crossed a line." It pushes us *towards* a problem, to change it. It can also land on the wrong person, or be far bigger than the problem.

For example: A woman keeps finding her lunch gone from the office fridge. Her anger tells her a line has been crossed, and gets her to raise it.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "What is this anger trying to protect?" "Is this about fairness, a blocked plan, or feeling unsafe?"

> TRY THIS:
> Next time you feel angry, finish this sentence privately: "I'm angry because something I care about, which is ___, seems ___."

02

Anger often guards a softer feeling.

Anger can arrive first because it feels stronger and safer than what sits under it: hurt, fear, shame, worry or plain tiredness. In Chapter 1 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings) we called this layers. Finding the layer underneath often shows what you actually need.

For example: A man snaps at his teenage daughter for coming home an hour late. Under the anger is a cold hour of fear: "What if something happened?" When he says that part, she hears it, and apologises.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm angry, and I think underneath I was really scared." "I came across cross. I think I'm actually hurt."

> TRY THIS:
> After the next angry moment, when you're calm, ask: "Was there hurt, fear or tiredness under it?"

03

Anger rises in the body fast.

A hot face, a tight jaw, a pounding heart, a louder voice, fists or shoulders tensing. This is the body getting ready for a fight, and it can happen in seconds. When anger is high, careful thinking and listening get much harder. Chapter 2 (page 25) calls this being flooded: so stirred up that the thinking part of you goes quiet for a while.

For example: Arguing about the bins, a woman notices her hands shaking and realises she can't hear a word her housemate says. That's her sign to stop.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "My body is ready for a fight. That doesn't mean I have to have one." "Where is this in my body?"

TRY THIS:
Learn your own early signs. Write down two or three, like "jaw tight" or "talking faster." They are your cue to slow down.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES
Anger moves faster than words. The Calm-Down Kit is a plan you make on a calm day, for the hot minutes.

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

04

In the hot minutes: slow the body first.

When anger is high, settle your body before you try to sort anything out. Simple steps help: stop talking or typing, breathe out slowly (longer out than in), unclench your hands, and if you can, move away for a while. A large review of 154 studies by Kjærvik and Bushman (2024) found that activities which calm the body, like slow breathing,

relaxation and mindfulness, reduced anger, while ones that rev you up showed little or no benefit.

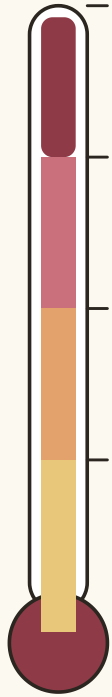
For example: A dad feels his temper rising while helping with homework. He says, "I'm getting frustrated, and that's not your fault. I'm going to get a glass of water and come back in five minutes." He does. The homework gets done.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm too angry to talk well right now. I'll come back at eight." "I need ten minutes. I'm not leaving the conversation, I'm coming back to it."

> TRY THIS:
> Make a three-step plan on a calm day: your early sign, the words you'll say, and where you'll go for ten minutes. Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) has steps for the hottest moments.

Anger rises fast

What helps depends on how hot it is.



Hot minutes
Slow the body first: long out-breaths. Step away, with a time to come back.

Angry
Don't solve it now. Problems can wait; sharp words are hard to take back.

Annoyed
Notice the body: hot face, tight jaw, clenched hands.

Irritated
Say it early, plainly and kindly.

✕ **Letting rip doesn't empty it. It feeds it.**

Once cooler: say it, don't throw it.
Then repair any sharp moments.

In a review of 154 studies (Kjærvik and Bushman, 2024), activities that calm the body reduced anger; revving it up did not help. If anger frightens or controls someone, safety comes first.

FIGURE 8 Anger rises fast, and what helps depends on how hot it is. In the hot minutes, slow the body first; letting rip feeds it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

The Calm-Down Kit
Pat, a grandmother raising her grandson Jay, 13

The Calm-Down Kit

Whose kit is this? (your name)
Pat (Nan)

Date
4 October 2026

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first
Door slammed after a call with his mum	*Shoulders up by my ears*
Being shouted at in front of the neighbours	*Hot face, can't find words*

Part A: My two defaults

First default
Gating (lower the lights, step out)

Second, if the first isn't available
Low, steady sound

Part A: My pause line

In my words
I'm too wound up to listen well. I'm putting the kettle on for twenty minutes. I'll come and find you at half past.

Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal
"Kettle time"

The shortest break we take
20 minutes

How we set the time to come back
Whoever pauses says a time before they go

The first sentence when we come back
"I'm back. Let's start again, slower."

Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

Part C: Coming back

Time	What I did	How I feel now
5:10 pm	*Gating (lower the lights, step out)*	*Settled enough*

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

Next
Settled enough: go back to the conversation, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action
Sit with Jay and agree one screen-time rule

If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up
After tea, at 6

☑ I'm going with this

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Jay agreed the pause plan with her on a calm Sunday. "Gating", one of the kit's calming steps, means cutting down what comes in through the senses: lower the lights, turn the sound down, or step out of the room.

Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11)

05

Letting rip doesn't empty it.

Many people believe anger is like steam: let it out, by shouting, slamming or hitting a pillow, and it will be gone. Research doesn't support this. In a well-known study by Bushman (2002), angry people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who annoyed them ended up angrier, not calmer.

So does going over and over what happened in your head: in studies by Bushman and colleagues (2005), people who dwelt on a provocation were later more aggressive, even towards someone who

only mildly annoyed them. Anger tends to fade faster when the body is calmed and the mind has something else to do for a while.

For example: After a row with a coworker, a man spends his lunch telling three people how awful she is. By the afternoon he's angrier than ever. Next time, he takes a walk instead, and by two o'clock he can think clearly.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "Going over this again is feeding it." "I can come back to this later, when I'm calmer."

> TRY THIS:
> If you notice yourself replaying an argument, set a timer for twenty minutes and do something absorbing. Come back to the problem after.

06

Step back and look from the outside.

Once the body has settled a little, it helps to look at the moment as if you were watching from across the room. What happened? What might the other person have been dealing with? In experiments by Mischkowski, Kross and Bushman (2012), people who looked back on an annoying moment "like a fly on the wall," rather than reliving it, felt less angry and acted less aggressively. Rethinking what happened, which psychologists call reappraisal (Gross, 1998), helps too.

For example: Furious that a friend cancelled again, a woman imagines telling the story to a kind stranger. Told that way, she remembers her friend is caring for a sick parent. The anger softens into worry.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "If I were watching this from the side, what would I see?" "What else might be going on for them?"

TRY THIS:

Write two lines about the moment, starting with your own name instead of "I": "Wes got angry because..."

07

Say it, don't throw it.

Anger is often a fair message sent in a hurtful way. When you are calmer, you can still say you were angry, and why, without attacking. A simple shape helps: what happened (the facts), how you felt, and what you're asking for.

For example: Instead of "You always let me down," a woman says to her sister: "When you cancelled Mum's appointment again, I felt really angry and alone with it. Can we make a plan for who takes her, for the next three months?"

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I was angry about what happened on Monday. Can I tell you why?" "When ___ happened, I felt ___. What I'm asking for is ___."

TRY THIS:

Write your angry message, then rewrite it in the three-part shape before you send anything. See Chapter 4 (page 43) for more on saying hard things.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: say it slowly, in one plain sentence. A soft start makes it easier for the other person to hear you.

TOOL **Soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

08

After anger, repair.

Everyone gets angry, and most of us say something sharp sometimes. What matters a great deal is what happens next. A short, real repair (naming what you did, without "but," and saying what you'll do differently) helps rebuild trust.

For example: A grandmother shouts at her grandson for breaking a vase, and he cries. An hour later she sits with him: "I shouted, and that was scary. The vase isn't as important as you. I'm sorry." He hugs her.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I was sharp with you earlier. That wasn't fair, and I'm sorry." "I'm still upset about what happened, and I also shouldn't have spoken to you that way."

TRY THIS:
Think of one recent moment when your anger landed on someone. Is there a short repair you could still make? Chapter 11 (page 97) has more on apologies that land.

09

When anger becomes harm.

Feeling angry is human. But some things done in anger are harm, whatever the feeling behind them: hitting, pushing, throwing things at or near someone, breaking their things, threatening, shouting so someone is scared, or using anger to control what another person does, wears, spends or who they see. People walking on eggshells around you is a sign too. Anger is never a reason someone deserves to be hurt.

For example: A man realises his partner and children go quiet when he comes home in a bad mood. He doesn't hit anyone, but they are afraid of him. He talks to his doctor and joins an anger course.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think my anger is scaring people I love. I want help with it." (If it's happening to you) "I'm frightened of how they get when they're angry."

TRY THIS:

If this sounds like you, see help with your own anger (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents). If you're afraid of someone else's anger, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn your early signs, settle your body, say what made you angry in words, and repair when you get it wrong. You can't make someone else calm down, and you don't have to accept being shouted at, threatened or controlled. If someone else's anger frightens you, getting safe matters more than working it out. Not safe at home?

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

You put the phone face down and walk round the block. Breathing out long, you notice what's under the anger: you're tired, and you're scared about Mum. Back home you send a different message: "I'm really frustrated. This is the third time and I feel alone with Mum's care. Can we talk tonight and make a plan?"

Your brother rings within ten minutes. His shifts have changed and he's been too embarrassed to say. You make a plan together. The anger was right that something needed to change. It just needed words instead of capitals.

If you're a teenager

A *made-up example.* Maisie, 16, has her phone taken at ten, mid-chat with her friends. She shouts and slams the door. The next morning, calmer, she says: "It felt like you didn't trust me. Sorry for the door. Could I have ten minutes' warning?" Her dad says yes.

Being angry with a parent is normal, and arguments often feel most intense in the middle teens. A rule given out of care isn't control, even when it feels unfair. A calm ask the next day works more often than a slammed door.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm too angry to talk properly. Can we talk tomorrow?" "It's not the rule I mind, it's how it happened." "Could we try it for two weeks and then check?"

In everyday life

- **On your own:** Anger at yourself counts too. "I'm so stupid" is anger turned inward. Speak to yourself as you would to a friend who made the same mistake. See Chapter 7 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-7-worth).
- **With a partner:** Agree on a pause word on a calm day, and a time you'll always come back. See When we keep having the same fight (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner).
- **Parents and children:** Children copy what we do with anger more than what we say about it. See For parents.
- **With family and friends:** Old anger can flare at gatherings. Plan a short break. See Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts).
- **At work:** Anger at work is common and rarely said. "I'm frustrated about the deadline change. Can we talk about what's realistic?" keeps it useful. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).

- **If you have ADHD:** Anger can arrive fast and big, then pass quickly. Plan for the speed: a three-word pause line ("Back in ten"), and a rule to wait before you send anything. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger-in-depth).
- **Managing a clash between two people:** Hear each person alone first, then together, about what happened, not about each other. Often the fight is about the setup, like two people who both think they own the same job. A worked example.

Common mix-ups

- **"Anger is a bad feeling."** Anger is a normal feeling. Some things done in anger are harmful. The feeling itself is information.
- **"Letting it out is healthy."** Shouting or hitting things tends to keep anger going. Calming the body and then talking helps more.
- **"They made me angry, so it's their fault I shouted."** Someone can do something unfair. What you do next is still yours.
- **"Holding it in is the safe option."** Swallowing anger for years tends to come out sideways: as coldness, sarcasm or a sudden explosion. Saying it calmly and early is safer.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Keep yourself safe first.** If someone's anger scares you, step away. You don't have to stay and calm them down.
- **Lower, slower, fewer words.** Speak quietly and simply. Don't argue the point while they are flooded.
- **Take the message, not the blow.** Often there's something fair under the anger. You can hear that part and still say the way it was said wasn't okay.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I want to hear this, and I can't while we're both shouting. Can we try again at seven?" "I can tell this really matters to you."

When to get more help

Everyone gets angry. It may be time to talk to a doctor, a counsellor or an anger management course if:

- your anger feels out of control, or you often regret what you do or say when angry;
- people close to you seem nervous or walk on eggshells around you;
- you have hit, pushed, thrown things, broken things or threatened anyone;
- anger is hurting your work, your friendships or your health;
- you are using alcohol or drugs to cope with angry feelings.

Help for anger works for many people: a review of anger treatments by Del Vecchio and O'Leary (2004) found medium to large benefits. It is good for your health too: a review by Chida and Steptoe (2009) linked anger and hostility with a higher risk of heart disease. Asking for help is a responsible thing to do. Help with your own anger has first steps.

If you are afraid of someone else's anger, that fear is an important signal. Not safe at home? lists free, private help. If you or anyone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

Reading **pages to read on the website**

- When we keep having the same fight and When one talks and one goes quiet (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw).
- How to apologise so it counts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages).
- The library: anger (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), going over and over things, rethinking versus holding it in, time-outs (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict) and managing flooding.

More for your situation

- For parents: help with your own anger · Repair after you've scared a child
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Family rifts · Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- At work
- Not safe at home?
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Anger is a signal** that something seems unfair, blocked or threatening. The feeling is allowed. What you do with it is the part you choose.
- ✓ **The first minutes are about the body.** Slow down, breathe out long, and step away with a time to come back.
- ✓ **Letting rip doesn't empty anger.** Shouting tends to feed it. Calming the body, then putting it into words and repairing any sharp moments, helps more.
- ✓ **Anger that frightens, controls or hurts someone has become harm.** That needs more help, and safety comes first.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 3 · Full tanks and different angles — Sharing the load
Leftover stress behind a reaction

Book 1 · How feelings work — Self-discovery
Feelings as signals

Chapter 6 · Healing after hurt — page 97
Repair after the hot minutes

Book 1 · Who you are becoming — Self-discovery
A Calm-Down Kit made on a calm day

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

Upset right now?
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger-in-depth

6

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 6 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 11

Healing after hurt: repair, forgiveness, and when to get help

How hurt heals: why it lingers, how small breaks get mended, what a real apology sounds like, what forgiveness is and isn't, and when it's time to get more help.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Hurt is real, and healing takes time
2. Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts
3. Telling someone they hurt you
4. A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it
5. Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back
6. You can heal even if they never say sorry
7. Trust comes back in small, kept promises
8. Going back is a choice. Safety comes first
9. Look after the hurt part of you
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Hurt is real, and healing takes time.** Replaying it doesn't mean you're weak. It means it mattered.
- **Repair is what counts.** Every close relationship has breaks. A real apology names it, owns it and mends it.
- **Forgiveness isn't going back.** You can forgive without forgetting, excusing or letting someone back in.

- **Safety comes first.** You can heal even if they never say sorry, and you never owe anyone a risk to your safety.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **"Get back in tune before you carry on" and "go back in with a clear sentence"** (Part Two, Chapter I (page 7)) are repair in small: breaks are normal, and coming back is the skill. Big idea: *tune how you send and receive.*
- **The monthly look-back** (Part Two, Chapter V (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5)) includes "look back even when nothing is slipping", because small hurts repaired early don't harden into resentment.

THURSDAY, 2AM

It was one sentence, three weeks ago. They've probably forgotten it. You haven't. It plays again, word for word, and you think of all the things you could have said back. You're tired of carrying it, and you don't know how to put it down.

Everyone gets hurt, and everyone hurts other people, mostly without meaning to. This chapter explains how hurt works, how relationships mend, and how you can heal, with or without the other person. It's for small hurts and bigger ones. If someone is hurting you on purpose, or you feel afraid, start with safety first: Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

01

Hurt is real, and healing takes time.

Being hurt by someone shows that something mattered: the person, your trust, your sense of being respected. The mind replays hurts because it's trying to understand them and keep you safe. Healing

isn't a straight line. The feeling can come back on an anniversary, or when something reminds you. That doesn't mean you've failed. It means you're still healing.

For example (on your own): Months after a friend said something cruel at a party, Kwesi feels a jolt when he hears that song again. He reminds himself: "That's an old bruise being pressed, not a new wound."

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "This hurts because it mattered." "A feeling coming back doesn't mean I'm back at the start."

TRY THIS:
When a hurt replays, notice it, name it ("there's that memory again"), and gently bring your attention to something in the room you can see or touch.

02

Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts.

No relationship is smooth all the time. People snap, forget, misread and let each other down. Research on parents and babies, on couples and on therapy all points the same way: breaks are normal. What matters most is whether they get mended. A small repair, done soon, often makes a relationship feel safer than if the break had never happened.

For example (a parent and child): Dad snaps at his son for spilling juice. Twenty minutes later he sits down next to him: "I was grumpy and I shouted. That wasn't fair. Spills happen. Want to help me make a new one?"

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

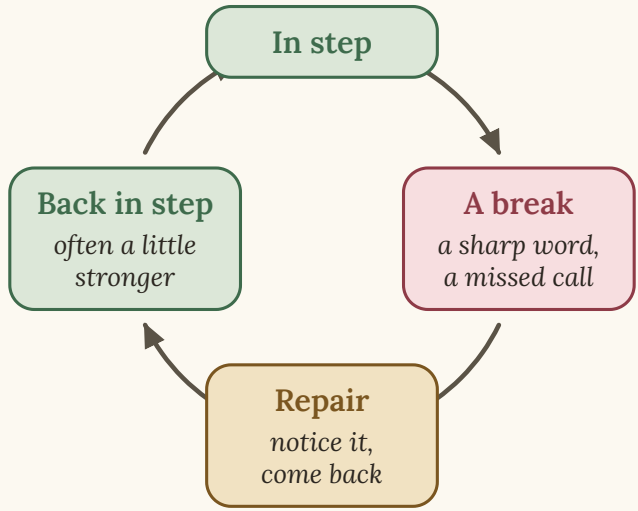
"Can I have a do-over? That came out badly." "I didn't like how I spoke to you earlier. I'm sorry."

TRY THIS:

Think of a small break this week, with anyone. Go back and repair it with one sentence.

Every close relationship has breaks

What counts is coming back.



A real apology

Name it	Own it	Mend it
say what you did	*no "but"*	*now and next time*

Trust comes back in small, kept promises.

Everyday breaks and repairs show up in parent and baby play (Tronick), in couples (Gottman's "repair attempts") and in therapy (Eubanks and colleagues, 2018).

FIGURE 9 Every close relationship has breaks; what counts is the repair. A real apology names it, owns it and mends it.

03

Telling someone they hurt you.

People can't mend what they don't know about. Saying "that hurt" is a risk, but it gives the relationship a chance. It works best when you describe what happened and how it felt, rather than what kind of person they are. Pick a calm moment, not the middle of an argument.

For example (a friend): Amara says to her friend: "When you told the group about my breakup before I was ready, I felt exposed. I'd like to be the one who shares my news." She didn't call her friend a gossip. She said what happened and what she needs.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"When… happened, I felt… What I'd like is…" "I'm telling you because I want us to be okay."

TRY THIS:

Write your sentence before you say it: what happened, how you felt, what you'd like. Keep it to three short lines.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

Talk it through in writing

Carys, writing to her brother Owen

Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Housemate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)

Owen

Your name (optional)

Carys

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · Make a plan · Say sorry · I need a pause

What happened (facts only, one thing)

At Dad's 70th on Saturday, you said to everyone at the table that I don't visit. I visited three times in September.

How it landed for me

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · *hurt* · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · *embarrassed* · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · grateful

What I'm asking for (one clear ask)

Could we talk on the phone this week about how we share the visits?

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)

I'm not angry with you as a person.

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Then the tool asks her to wait before she sends it.

Fill in your own: Talk it through in writing

(spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through)

04

A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it.

"Sorry if you were upset" doesn't heal much. A real apology says what you did, takes responsibility without excuses, shows you understand how it affected the other person, and offers to put it right or do things differently. Research, such as a study led by Roy Lewicki (2016), suggests owning it and offering repair are the parts that matter most.

For example (a coworker): Leila presented a shared idea in a meeting as if it were hers. The next day she tells her colleague: "I presented our idea as mine. That wasn't fair to you. I'll email the team today and say it was joint work."

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I did… That was my doing. I can see it left you feeling… Here's what I'll do."

TRY THIS:

Next time you say sorry, check for the four parts: what I did, it was mine, how it affected you, what I'll do now. See Apology languages (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages) for more.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

An apology lands best when it's plain: what happened, that it was yours, and what you'll do now. The step-by-step reset can help you find those words.

TOOL **After a talk went wrong: a step-by-step reset** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

05

Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back.

Forgiveness is usually described as letting go of resentment and the wish to get even. It's something that happens inside you. It doesn't mean saying what happened was okay. It doesn't mean forgetting.

And it doesn't mean you have to trust the person again or have them in your life. Forgiveness is a choice, often a slow one, and you never owe it on someone else's timetable.

For example (a grown-up child and a parent): Danielle forgave her father for missing much of her childhood. She still keeps visits short, and she still doesn't leave her kids alone with him when he drinks. Forgiving him and protecting her family both feel right.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "I can let go of wanting to get even, and still keep my limits." "I don't have to forgive today. I can just stop feeding the anger today."

> TRY THIS:
> Write down what forgiving someone would mean to you, and what it would not mean. Seeing the difference can make it feel possible, or show you that you aren't ready, which is fine too.

06

You can heal even if they never say sorry.

Waiting for an apology that never comes can keep you stuck. The person may be gone, unwilling, or unable to understand. Healing doesn't have to depend on them. You can make sense of what happened, tell your story to someone safe, and decide what it means for you now.

For example (an ex-partner): After a hard breakup, Martha writes a letter she never sends. She says everything: what hurt, what she wished, what she's taking with her. Then she puts it away. Nothing changed for him. Something shifted for her.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "I don't need them to understand for my healing to count."

TRY THIS:

Write about the hurt for fifteen minutes, three or four days in a row. Write about the facts and your feelings. If it ever makes you feel much worse, stop, and talk to someone instead.

07

Trust comes back in small, kept promises.

After trust is broken, one big apology rarely rebuilds it. Trust grows back slowly, in many small moments where someone does what they said they'd do. If you broke trust, being patient and consistent matters more than a grand gesture. If you were let down, it's fair to watch what someone does, not just what they say.

For example (partners): Declan hid a credit card debt from his partner. After it came out, he offered to share his bank statements each month, without being asked. After a year of small, steady openness, his partner says she can breathe again.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I know my words aren't enough. I want to show you, over time."
"I need to see it for a while before I can feel it."

TRY THIS:

If you're rebuilding trust, choose one small promise you can keep every week, and keep it.

08

Going back is a choice. Safety comes first.

After a hurt, you can mend the relationship, change its shape, or step away. All three can be healthy. If someone keeps hurting you after you've told them, if you feel afraid of them, or if they control, threaten or put you down, the work is to protect yourself, not to repair. Counselling together isn't advised when someone is afraid of their partner.

For example (housemates): Ellie's housemate borrowed money twice and didn't pay it back. Ellie forgave the first time. The second time, she said: "I won't lend money again. I still want us to get on in the house." A limit, not a war.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm not angry any more, and I'm not going back to how it was." "I need some distance while I work out what I want."

TRY THIS:

Ask yourself three questions: Is it safe? Has the hurt stopped? Do I want this relationship in my life? Your answers can guide what comes next. If you feel unsafe, see signs to look out for.

09

Look after the hurt part of you.

Hurt lives in the body as well as the mind: poor sleep, a tight chest, feeling jumpy. Healing goes better with basic care: rest, food, movement, people who are kind to you, and talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a hurting friend. Some people find they grow after something painful. That can happen, but it's not a test you have to pass.

For example (a stranger): A man shouted at Idris on the bus, calling him names. For days he felt shaky. He told a friend, went for long walks, and said to himself, "That was about him, not me. I'm safe now." Slowly, the shakiness faded.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"This was hard. Anyone would be shaken. What do I need right now?"

TRY THIS:

Pick one small act of care for today: an early night, a walk, a warm drink, a call to someone kind. Calm tools are in Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can say what hurt, apologise for what you did, and look after your own healing. You can't make someone apologise, understand or change, and you don't have to wait for them to start feeling better. Forgiveness, trust and going back are all yours to choose, in your own time.

SATURDAY, 11AM

You've written it all down, every word of it. Then a smaller version: "When you said that, I felt small. I'd like you to know." You haven't decided whether to send it. But the 2am replays have gone quieter, because now it's on paper, not just in your head.

In everyday life

- **On your own:** Writing the hurt down, every word, then a shorter version, can quieten the replays. You don't have to send it.
- **With a partner:** Small breaks happen daily. A quick "That came out wrong. Can I try again?" mends most of them. See How to apologise so it counts.
- **Family:** Old family hurts often need a different talk from new ones, and sometimes more time apart. See Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts).
- **Friends:** A friend may not know they hurt you. "Can I tell you something that stung? I'd rather say it than drift." keeps the door open.

- **At work:** Keep it to the facts and what you need next time. A short note afterwards helps both of you remember the same thing.
- **After someone has died:** You can still heal a hurt with someone who is gone, by writing to them or talking it through with someone you trust. See Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief).
- **After an affair:** The shock is real for both people. Couples can recover, and some decide to part; both can be done with care. Trust returns through kept promises over months, and a couples therapist can help. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth).
- **If you decide to separate:** Part as kindly as you can. Tell children together, without blame, and never ask them to choose. Write decisions down, and consider family mediation where it's safe. More in the full chapter.

Common mix-ups

- **"If I forgive, I'm saying it was okay."** Forgiving isn't excusing. You can forgive and still say it was wrong.
- **"If I forgive, I have to let them back in."** Forgiveness and going back are separate choices.
- **"A good relationship never has breaks."** Every close relationship has them. Mending them is what builds safety.
- **"Saying sorry means it's fixed."** An apology opens the door. Trust comes back through what happens next.
- **"I should be over this by now."** Healing has no deadline. Feelings returning doesn't mean you're back at the start.
- **"I can't heal unless they admit it."** Their apology can help, but your healing can go ahead without it.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Listen before you advise.** "That sounds really painful" helps more than "You should just let it go."
- **Don't rush forgiveness.** Pushing someone to forgive can feel like being told their hurt doesn't matter.
- **Don't push them to cut someone off, either.** It's their relationship and their choice, unless they're in danger.
- **If you caused the hurt,** give a real apology and then give them time. Don't ask them to make you feel better about it.
- **If they mention fear, threats or control,** take it seriously and share Not safe at home?

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Do you want to talk it through, or would it help more to take your mind off it?" "Whatever you decide about them, I'm on your side."

When to get more help

Some hurts are too heavy to carry alone, and getting help is a sign of strength, not weakness. Think about talking to a doctor, counsellor or therapist if:

- More than a month after something frightening, you still have flashbacks, nightmares, feel constantly on edge, or avoid places and people that remind you of it. These can be signs of trauma, and there are well-tested treatments for it, such as trauma-focused talking therapies.
- The hurt is taking over: you can't sleep, work or enjoy anything, or you're drinking or using more to cope.
- The hurt came from abuse or violence, now or in the past. The page Free, private people to talk to includes specialist lines.

- You're having thoughts of hurting yourself or someone else. Please reach out today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If anyone is in danger now, call your local emergency number.

If you and someone else both want to mend things, a couples or family counsellor can help, as long as nobody is afraid of the other.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? for calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) for checking your state.

Reading **pages to read on the website**

- Apology languages: how to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness.
- Library: forgiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict), what research says about apologies and repair attempts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships).
- Library: rumination (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), expressive writing and self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).
- Stories from philosophy: the Second Arrow (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth).

More for your situation

- **Families:** Adult siblings and family rifts · For grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children)

- **After a breakup:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting)
- **Friends:** When a friendship drifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Children who have been hurt:** Foster, adoptive and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

More in Part Three

← Chapter 10: Values, meaning and a good life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-10-values) · Chapter 12: Helping others well → (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-12-helping) · All chapters in the contents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents)

A limit to keep in mind: This chapter is for everyday hurts and for thinking about bigger ones. It isn't therapy, and it isn't a reason to stay somewhere unsafe. If you're afraid of someone, the most healing step is getting safe. Not safe at home?

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Hurt is real, and healing takes time.** Replaying it doesn't mean you're weak. It means it mattered.
- ✓ **Repair is what counts.** Every close relationship has breaks. A real apology names it, owns it and mends it.
- ✓ **Forgiveness isn't going back.** You can forgive without forgetting, excusing or letting someone back in.
- ✓ **Safety comes first.** You can heal even if they never say sorry, and you never owe anyone a risk to your safety.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 3 · Two kinds of fair
Covering kindly and saying it out loud — Sharing the load

Chapter 3 · How communication works
Repair in everyday talk — page 43

Chapter 5 · Anger
When anger did the damage — page 79

Book 1 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
Guilt without shame — Self-discovery

PUT IT TO USE

Upset right now?
For calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder for checking your state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Apology languages
How to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth

7

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 7 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 15

Closeness and love: being known, at every age

How closeness grows, what it means to feel truly known, how love changes over the years, and how it looks in every kind of relationship, at every age, including for people on their own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Love comes in many forms
2. Closeness grows from being known
3. Closeness is built a step at a time
4. Feeling understood matters most
5. Old maps show up in love
6. Love changes over time
7. Love at every age
8. Love is something you do
9. If you're a teenager
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Love comes in many forms.** Friends, family, partners, chosen family and the love you give yourself are all real love.
- **Closeness grows from being known.** You share something real, and the other person responds with understanding and care.
- **Love changes over time.** Early excitement often settles, and long love can stay warm, close and even exciting.
- **Love is something you do,** in small ways, every day. It never includes fear or control.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **The 90-second daily check-in** (Part Two, Chapter I (page 7)) has an appreciation line, because closeness grows from small, frequent moments of being seen and known.
- **Who did what** (the Preface to Part Two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface)) matters for love too: work one person never sees slowly wears closeness down. Big idea: *see the whole load.*

> FRIDAY, 10:30PM
>
> *You and Charlie have shared a home for eleven years. Tonight you're both on the sofa, both on your phones. You realise you can't remember the last time you talked about anything except bills, the boiler and whose turn it is to cook. You love Charlie. You just feel, oddly, a little alone in the same room.*

This chapter isn't only about romance. It's about closeness in all its forms: what helps people feel near to each other, why it can fade, and how it can grow again. It builds on Chapter 5 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-5-belonging), on attachment and trust.

01

Love comes in many forms.

The ancient Greeks had several words for love: for friends, for family, for romantic partners and for strangers. Today people love in many ways too: lifelong friendships, partners of any gender, people with more than one partner, chosen family, people who are asexual or aromantic and build deep closeness without romance or sex, and people on their own who pour love into friends, family, pets, work

and community. No form is the "real" one. A life can be full of love without a partner in it.

For example: A woman in her fifties who has never wanted a partner says her closest relationship is with her best friend of thirty years. They've been through two house moves, one cancer scare and countless Sunday phone calls. "That's my great love story," she says.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
"Who are the people I love, in all the forms it takes?" "The love I have counts, even if it doesn't look like a film."

TRY THIS:
Write down three people (or more) you love, of any kind. Next to each, write one way you show it.

02
Closeness grows from being known.

Intimacy isn't only about touch or romance. At its heart is being known. Psychologists Reis and Shaver described it as a back-and-forth: one person shares something real about themselves, and the other responds in a way that leaves them feeling understood, accepted and cared for. In a diary study by Laurenceau, Barrett and Pietromonaco (1998), feeling that the other person really responded was a big part of what made everyday conversations feel intimate.

For example: Two brothers who talk mainly about football are driving to their dad's care home. One says, "I find these visits really hard." The other says, "Me too. I always feel guilty on the way home." They've never felt closer.

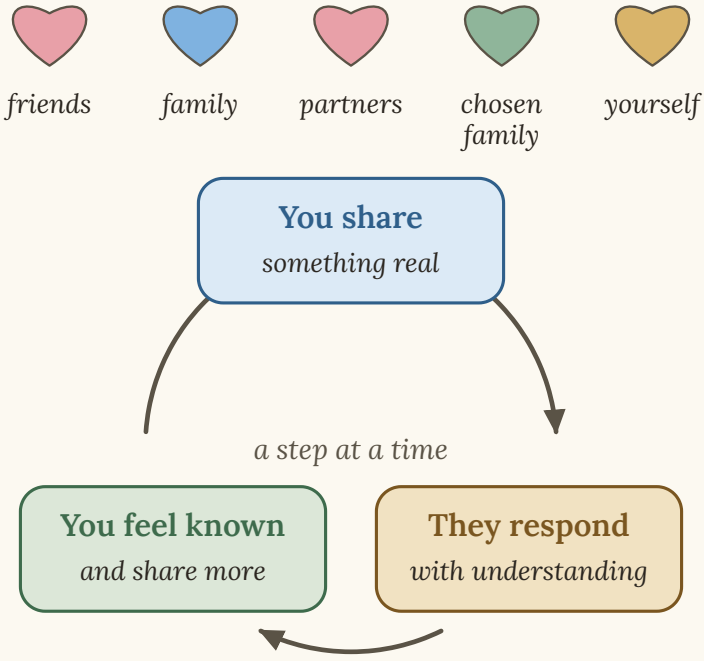
WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Can I tell you something I haven't said out loud before?" "Thank you for telling me. That makes sense."

TRY THIS:

Share one small, true thing with someone you care about: a worry, a hope, or something that made you happy this week. Then notice how they respond.

Closeness grows from being known

Love comes in many forms. It grows the same way.



Love is something you do, in small ways.
It never includes fear or control.

After Reis and Shaver's intimacy process model (1988), supported by diary studies (Laurenceau and colleagues, 1998).

FIGURE 10 Closeness grows from being known: you share something real, the other person responds with understanding, and you share a little more.

03

Closeness is built a step at a time.

People usually get close by sharing a little more, and a little more, when it feels safe. In a well-known study by Aron and colleagues (1997), pairs of strangers who took turns asking gradually more personal questions (now known as the "36 questions") felt closer after 45 minutes than pairs who made small talk. The same idea works in friendships and long relationships: closeness grows when both people take small, matched steps.

For example: Two new neighbours start with weather and parking. Over a few months, it becomes "How's your mum doing?" and later, "Can I tell you what's really been going on?" Neither rushed it.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "What's something you're looking forward to?" "What's been on your mind lately?" "What was the best part of your week?"

TRY THIS:
Ask someone one question a little deeper than usual. If they answer, share something of your own back.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES
Closeness grows when you know what feels like care to the other person, not just to you. A care card is a gentle way to find out.

TOOL **What feels like care to me: a care card** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

04

Feeling understood matters most.

What makes someone feel loved is often less about grand gestures and more about feeling understood. Researchers call this *responsiveness*: noticing, understanding and caring about what matters to the other person. It shows in small moments, like how you react to good news. Gable and colleagues (2004) found that people

whose partners usually met their good news with real interest and warmth felt closer and more satisfied together.

For example: A teenager says, "I got picked for the band!" Her grandad stops what he's doing, smiles, and asks, "What instrument? When's the first concert?" She talks for twenty minutes.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Tell me everything!" "That sounds like it really mattered to you." "What was that like?"

> TRY THIS:
> The next time someone shares good news, put your phone down and ask two follow-up questions.

05

Old maps show up in love.

The patterns from Chapter 5 often come out most strongly with the people we love most. Hazan and Shaver (1987) suggested that adult love uses the same attachment system as childhood bonds. When closeness feels shaky, some people reach harder for reassurance; others pull back to feel safe. Neither is bad. Both are ways of protecting something precious.

For example: When his partner goes quiet, Leo texts five times in an hour. His partner, who goes quiet to calm down, feels crowded. They agree: "I need an hour, and I'll message you at eight." Leo can wait for a known time.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm feeling unsure of us right now. Can you tell me we're okay?" "I need some space, and I'm coming back. Let's talk at eight."

TRY THIS:

Notice what you do when closeness feels shaky: reach out, pull back, or both. Tell someone you trust what helps you feel safe again.

06

Love changes over time.

Early love is often intense, with racing thoughts and a lot of longing. Over years, it usually settles into something calmer and deeper. That isn't failure. A review by Acevedo and Aron (2009) found that some people in long relationships still report strong romantic love, without the anxious, obsessive edge of early love, and that this was linked to being happier together.

In experiments by Aron and colleagues (2000), couples who tried a new, mildly challenging activity together felt better about their relationship afterwards than couples given a dull task.

For example: After twenty-five years, a couple take a pottery class. They're both terrible at it and laugh all evening. On the way home, one says, "I feel like we're on a date."

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Calm isn't the same as cold." "What could we try that's new for both of us?"

TRY THIS:

Plan one small new thing with someone you love: a new walk, a new recipe, a new place. New for both of you matters more than big.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: little rituals, like a Sunday walk or a goodnight text, keep love warm through the years. Look after the ones you have.

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15

07

Love at every age.

Love looks different across a life. Teenagers' first loves can be huge and real. Adults juggle love with work, children and caring for parents. Many older people choose to spend their time with fewer, closer people. Carstensen and colleagues (1999) linked this to feeling that time is more limited, which makes the most meaningful relationships matter more. People find new love at seventy and eighty. People lose great loves and carry them always. All of it counts.

For example: A widower of seventy-eight meets a woman at his walking group. His children are surprised. He says, "I loved your mother for fifty years. I still do. And I'm allowed to be happy now."

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"It's never too late to be close to someone." "Missing someone is a form of love too."

TRY THIS:

Reach out to someone from another generation this week: an older relative, a younger neighbour or a colleague. Ask them about love in their life, if it feels right.

08

Love is something you do.

Feelings of love come and go. The actions of love can be steady: turning towards someone when they speak, keeping small promises, saying thank you, saying sorry, making room for who they are.

Physical closeness, like a hug or holding hands, matters a lot to some people and less to others, and sex is part of closeness for some relationships and not others. What matters is that both people feel comfortable and free to say yes or no. Love never includes fear, threats or control.

For example: A friend notices her friend has been quiet since his divorce. She doesn't say "I love you," but every Thursday she texts, "Walk?" and turns up. That is love too.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"What makes you feel most loved by me?" "Is this okay for you?" "I noticed you've been quiet. I'm here."

TRY THIS:

Ask someone you love, "What's one small thing that makes you feel cared for?" Then do it this week.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

Our time-together deal

Jamal and Tess, a couple; Jamal games most evenings

Our time-together deal

Your name
Jamal

Their name
Tess

Game nights (or long phone time)
Tuesday and Friday evenings, plus Sunday afternoon

Heads-up rule
Say before a session over an hour, and roughly when it ends.

When one of us asks for time
Finish this match, then I'm yours. No new one.

Our protected evening
Wednesday, from 7: we cook together

Phone-free times
Dinner, and the first 20 minutes in bed

Chores before the session
Dishes and our own jobs for the day are done first.

YOUR DEAL, READY TO SEND

Our time-together deal (Jamal and Tess), with each line above. A link holds the deal as it is right now: if either of you changes something, send a new link.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented.

Fill in your own: Our time-together deal
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can share a little of yourself, listen well, turn towards the people you love and keep small promises. You can't make someone love you, or love you in the way you want. If closeness keeps hurting you, or you feel afraid, that is not a failure of love on your part. Not safe at home?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

THE NEXT FRIDAY, 10:30PM

This time you leave both phones in the kitchen. You make two cups of tea and ask, "What's something you've been thinking about lately that you haven't told me?" Charlie is quiet for a moment, then talks about their dad getting older, and how scared they are of the phone ringing. You listen, and share your own worry about work. It's midnight before you notice the time. Nothing big was fixed. But you both feel known again.

If you're a teenager

First love can be huge and real. So can a first breakup. A *made-up example*: Ines, 16, is dumped by message on a Tuesday night and cries until 2am. "You'll get over it" from an adult doesn't help. What does: telling her cousin, who just listens; muting the chat instead of rereading it; and a rule of no checking their profile after ten. Weeks later she notices a whole day without thinking about it.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't need advice, I just need to tell someone." "Can we reply when we can, not all day?" If you're ending it: "I don't want to go out any more. I'm sorry. It isn't about something you did wrong."

In everyday life

On your own

Being single, widowed, divorced or happily alone doesn't mean a life without love. Friendships, family, community and the way you treat yourself are all places where love lives. If you want a partner and don't have one, that longing is real and worth being gentle with. See On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) and Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief).

- **Partners:** Most partners drift into talking only about jobs and bills. One real question a week can bring you back. See Turning towards (spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward) and Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins).
- **More than two partners:** Closeness with each person needs its own time and attention. See More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).
- **Friends:** Friendship is love too, and it needs tending like any other. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).

- **Family:** Parents, children, siblings and grandparents often love each other deeply and say it rarely. A short "I'm glad you're my sister" can mean a lot.
- **Long distance:** Being known can still happen across miles, through small, regular check-ins. See Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance).
- **Different levels of desire:** Very common in long relationships, and nobody's fault. Talk at a calm time, keep some affection that doesn't have to lead anywhere, and remember a kind "no" isn't a rejection of the person. A qualified sex therapist or couples therapist can help. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-15-love-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

- **"Real love means a romantic partner."** Friendship, family and chosen family are real love.
- **"If the spark fades, love is over."** Early intensity usually settles. Many long relationships stay warm, close and lively.
- **"If they loved me, they'd just know what I need."** Nobody reads minds. Saying what helps is a gift, not a failure.
- **"Jealousy proves love."** Feeling jealous is human, and asking for something out of care for the relationship is not control. Checking up without agreement, cutting someone off or punishing them is not love. See signs to look out for.
- **"Intimacy means sex."** Intimacy means being known. It can include physical closeness, or not.
- **"Love should be effortless."** Love usually takes small, steady effort, and that effort is part of what love is.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Respect their kind of love.** Don't assume everyone wants a partner, children or one kind of relationship.
- **Be a safe person to tell things to.** Listen without judging, and keep what they share private.
- **After a loss or breakup, keep showing up.** Many people get lots of support for two weeks and then very little.
- **If you're worried about someone's relationship,** stay close and kind rather than criticising their partner. If they seem afraid, gently share Not safe at home?

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm always glad to hear from you." "You don't have to explain your relationship to me. I just want you to be happy and safe."

When to get more help

- If you feel very lonely or low most days for two weeks or more, talk to a doctor or counsellor.
- If closeness feels frightening, or you keep ending up in relationships that hurt you, a counsellor or therapist can help you understand why.
- Couples, family or relationship counselling can help when you feel stuck, distant or keep having the same fight.
- If someone you love controls you, frightens you, checks your phone, cuts you off from friends or pressures you into anything you don't want, that isn't love. Not safe at home? lists free, private help.
- If you're in danger now, call your local emergency number. Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) can help you take the first step.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

Reading on the website

Reading pages to read on the website

- Bonding: how closeness grows (spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding): what research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family and you.
- Turning towards: small daily moments of connection.
- The languages of connection (spreadloveandacceptance.com/languages-of-connection): the different ways people show care.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency): why good things fade, and how to keep them alive.
- The library: responsiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships), love maps, self-expansion, adult attachment and sharing good news (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).

More for your situation

- Part Three, Chapter 5: Attachment, trust and belonging
- Friends · More than two · Long distance
- Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- On my own · Grief and later life
- Retired together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Love comes in many forms.** Friends, family, partners, chosen family and the love you give yourself are all real love.
- ✓ **Closeness grows from being known.** You share something real, and the other person responds with understanding and care.
- ✓ **Love changes over time.** Early excitement often settles, and long love can stay warm, close and even exciting.
- ✓ **Love is something you do,** in small ways, every day. It never includes fear or control.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 4 · Attachment, trust and belonging
Attachment and trust — Understanding people

Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune
Staying in tune day to day — page 7

Book 3 · The work nobody sees
Noticing the work love does — Sharing the load

Book 1 · Who you are becoming
Growing as a person inside a relationship — Self-discovery

PUT IT TO USE

Bonding: how closeness grows
What research says about closeness, with small ideas for partners, kids, friends, family and you
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

Turning towards
Small daily moments of connection
spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-15-love-in-depth

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool the chapters point to, in two separate lists, with the chapters that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02
In: Stress and the nervous system (page 25)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09
In: Why we get out of tune (page 7), How communication works (page 43)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11
In: Stress and the nervous system (page 25), Anger (page 79)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13
In: Why we get out of tune (page 7)

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15
In: Closeness and love (page 115)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator
In: How communication works (page 43), How we see each other (page 63)

TOOL **After a talk went wrong: a step-by-step reset** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder`

In: Why we get out of tune (page 7), How communication works (page 43), How we see each other (page 63), Healing after hurt (page 97)

TOOL **Make a pause plan for arguments** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw`

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 25), Anger (page 79)

TOOL **Weekly check-in card** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins`

In: How communication works (page 43), Closeness and love (page 115)

TOOL **Get one small bonding idea** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding`

In: Closeness and love (page 115)

TOOL **What feels like care to me: a care card** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages`

In: Closeness and love (page 115)

TOOL **How I like to be spoken to: a one-page card** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card`

In: How communication works (page 43)

TOOL **Compare your daily rhythms** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration`

In: Why we get out of tune (page 7)

TOOL **Upset right now? A 5-minute calm-down** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now`

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 25), How communication works (page 43), Anger (page 79), Healing after hurt (page 97), Closeness and love (page 115)

TOOL **Soften a tense moment** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment`

In: Anger (page 79)

TOOL **Calm sounds and music** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes`

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 25)

TOOL **Talk it through in writing** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through`

In: Healing after hurt (page 97)

TOOL **Handoff-bag checklist for two homes** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting`

In: How communication works (page 43), How we see each other (page 63), Healing after hurt (page 97)

TOOL **Room agreement for roommates** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room`

In: How communication works (page 43)

TOOL **10-minute team check-in** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/work`

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 25), How we see each other (page 63), Anger (page 79)

TOOL **Connect two fields of study** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath`

In: Why we get out of tune (page 7)

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Battery
Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, your load: a higher load score means a heavier load, and a lower battery.

Calm-Down Kit
The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

Carrier wave
The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

Check-in
A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Complacency
Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

Double empathy
The idea, from the autistic researcher Damian Milton, that misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people run both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so neither side is simply "missing" something.

Drift
Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

Flooded
Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

Frequency
Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

Kinship care
When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder
Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. Today's Weather calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Pressure

Pressure, in Today's Weather, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

Retune

To retune is to notice you've fallen out of step with someone and adjust together: slower, softer, or at a better time.

Rumination

Going over the same worry or regret again and again without getting closer to an answer.

Second arrow

The extra pain we add on top of a hard moment, such as being angry at ourselves for being sad. The first arrow is the event; the second is what we tell ourselves about it (a Buddhist image).

Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?: a load score from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 to 0.59 moderate, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

Today's Weather

Today's Weather is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Window of tolerance

The range in which you can feel strong feelings and still think and talk. Above it you are flooded or revved up; below it you shut down. A phrase from the psychiatrist Dan Siegel.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper

A workpaper is a short worksheet. Each person fills in their own, then you read them together.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

Research notes



The 135 studies and books these chapters mention, in short. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/research`.

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